



SQF Food Safety Audit Edition 9

Once Again Nut Butter - Once Again Nut Butter

Summary

AUDIT DECISION
CERTIFIED

CERTIFICATION NUMBER
103543 | 152099

AUDIT RATING



Good

DECISION DATE
05/17/2022

AUDIT TYPE
UNANNOUNCED

RECERTIFICATION DATE
03/27/2023

AUDIT DATES
04/12/2022 - 04/14/2022

EXPIRATION DATE
06/10/2023

ISSUE DATE
05/17/2022

Facility & Scope

Once Again Nut Butter (43515)



Once Again Nut Butter
12 South State St.
9365 State Rte. 408
P.O. Box 429
Nunda, NY 14517
United States

Web Site: <http://onceagainnutbutter.com>

Food Sector Categories:

14. Fruit, Vegetable, and Nut Processing, and Fruit Juices

Products:

Almonds, Almond Butter, Cashews, Cashew Butter, Nut Butter,
Peanuts, Peanut Butter, Seeds, Seed Butter

Scope of Certification:

Almonds, Almond Butter, Cashews, Cashew Butter, Nut Butter,
Peanuts, Peanut Butter, Seeds, Seed Butter

Certification Body & Audit Team

Mérieux NutriSciences Certification

401 N Michigan
Suite 1400
Chicago, IL 60611
United States

Web Site: <https://www.merieuxnutrisciences.com/>

CB#: CB-1-Mérieux

Accreditation Body: JAS-ANZ

Accreditation Number: Z3720906AB

Lead Auditor: Muir, Stephen (10048)

Technical Reviewer: Lastra, Jaime (10049)

Hours Spent on Site: 26

Hours of ICT Activities: 0

Hours Spent Writing Report: 8

Non-Conforming

2.4.3 Food Safety Plan (Mandatory)

A multidisciplinary team that included the SQF practitioners and site personnel with technical, production, and engineering knowledge of the relevant raw materials, packaging, processing aids, products, and associated processes was responsible for the development and maintenance of five (5) HACCP-based food safety plans including; Dry Roasted Peanuts; Peanut Butter; Tree Nut Butter; Seed Butter, and Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds. A product description that detailed the following; Product Name(s); Process Type; Important Food Safety Characteristics; Ingredients; Packaging; Intended Use; Intended Consumer; Shelf Life; Labeling Instructions (related to food safety); and Storage and Distribution was documented for each food safety plan. The dry roasted peanuts including whole peanuts, peanut splits and granulated peanuts had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of five (5) months from date of manufacture. The peanut butter and spreads contained varying sizes of peanut particulates depending on variety, some varieties were flavored, fortified or contained additional particulates. The peanut butter and spreads had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of twelve (12) to eighteen (18) months from date of manufacture, depending on variety. The tree nut butter, including almond and cashew butters contained varying sizes of nut particulates depending on variety, some varieties were flavored, fortified or contained additional particulates, had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of twelve (12) to eighteen (18) months from date of manufacture, depending on variety. The seed butters, including sesame, sunflower and Tahini may contain oils, sugar, flavorings or salt, had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of twelve (12) months from date of manufacture, depending on variety. Product labels complied with the allergen labeling requirements, peanuts, almond, cashews, sesame seed, and sunflower were listed in the ingredient declaration. For almond and cashew an allergen warning statement "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, sesame seeds and on equipment that processes other tree nuts, for sunflower a "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, tree nuts and on equipment that processes sesame", and for sesame "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, and tree nuts" was used. The bulk packed whole nuts, including almonds, Tamari almonds, cashews and bulk packaged seeds had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of five (5) months from date of manufacture. The intended use of the peanut, peanut butter and spreads, tree nut butter, seed butters, and bulk packed whole nuts was as a ready-to-eat products or an ingredient. The intended consumer was the general public, food manufacturers and restaurants. Appropriately detailed flow diagrams were documented for the following processes; Almond room; Boxed Nut and Seeds; Seed room; Bulk room - Almond; Bulk room - Cashew; Main facility - Receiving & Storage; Main Facility - Squeeze pack; Peanut Butter (PB) HACCP flow; PB facility - Receiving & Storage; PB Facility - Squeeze pack; PB Facility - Boxed peanuts; and Rework. The biological, chemical, physical food safety hazards that could reasonably be expected to occur at each step in the processes, including raw materials and other inputs were identified and documented. A hazard analysis was completed and reviewed for the following; raw materials, almond room, boxed peanuts, boxed tree nuts, bulk room - almond butter, bulk room - cashew butter, PB facility, receiving and storage, rework, seed room, and tree nut room. The raw material analysis included an evaluation of likelihood and severity to determine the significance of the potential hazards identified. The control measures that were applied to all significant hazards were identified and documented, including Supply Chain, Sanitation and Allergen preventive controls (PCs). The Supply Chain PCs were identified for; Labels - sourced from approved suppliers and the supplier to maintain only the current version for each label in their system; Allergens - ingredients sourced from approved suppliers; Aflatoxin - raw material sourced from only approved suppliers who sort to remove moldy nuts/seeds; Unapproved pesticides - sourced from approved suppliers who monitor growers; Foreign material - raw materials sourced from approved suppliers who utilize foreign material control methods; and Pathogenic bacteria - almonds pasteurized (5 log reduction) before delivery. The Sanitation PC were identified for zoning and related GMP control; cleaning and sanitation; and microbiological verification of the sanitation practices. The Allergen PC was identified for the nut receiving process step and code/label/brand process steps, undeclared allergens was the significant chemical food safety hazard controlled, and the correct ingredient and allergen information printed on the labels applied to the raw material and finished product were the critical criteria. Three (3) process preventive controls/critical control points (PPCs/CCPs) were identified as an outcome of the hazard analyses which included; CCP #1 - identified for the thermal process/pathogen reduction process step, including dry roasting, oil roasting, and the use of the Neo-Pure sanitizing solution for cashews; CCP #2 - for the metal detection process step; and CCP #2-A - for the glass container cleaning/air rinsing process step. CCP #1 - dry roasting and CCP #2 - metal detection were applicable to the dry roasted peanuts FSP, CCP #1 - bulk nut roasting, CCP #2 - metal detection, and CCP #2-A - glass container cleaning were applicable to the Peanut Butter FSP, CCP #2 - metal detection and CCP #2-A - glass container cleaning were applicable to the Tree Nut Butter FSP, CCP #1 - seed roasting, CCP #2 - metal detection, and CCP #2-A - glass container cleaning were applicable to the Seed Butter FSP, and CCP #1 - oil roasting and/or dry roasting and CCP #2 - metal detection were applicable to the Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds FSP. The use of the Neo-Pure sanitizing solution was detailed as a process preventive control in the cashew room but not as a CCP in the Nut Butter CCP determination documentation. Non sporeforming pathogens such as Salmonella was the significant biological food safety hazard controlled by CCP #1. For the dry roasted peanut and peanut butter food safety plans, the critical limits for old fashion peanuts included; start up time ≥ 25 minutes at a temperature ≥ 320 deg F, roast time ≥ 20 minutes at a temperature ≥ 305 deg F, and a bed depth 22 minutes at a temperature ≥ 295 deg F, and a bed depth 30 minutes at 300 deg F for sunflower seeds and a roast time of ≥ 35 minutes at 290 deg F for sesame seeds; for the bulk tree nuts and seeds food safety plan, the critical limits were a minimum oil temperature of 350 deg F and a minimum roast time of four (4) minutes and fifty one (51) seconds; and for the Neo-Pure sanitizer application for cashews, the critical limits were a minimum application rate of 80ml/kg and a minimum hold time of ten (10) minutes. Metal inclusion was the significant physical food safety hazard controlled by CCP #2 and the critical limits were a metal detector in place and operating to standard and no metal fragments that would cause injury or a choking hazard. Glass inclusion was the significant physical food safety hazard controlled by CCP #2-A, and the critical limits included, a glass cleaner in place and operating to standard and no glass fragments that would cause injury or a choking hazard. A monitoring procedure that detailed the "What, How, Frequency and Who" was documented for each CCP. CCP #1 for peanuts and peanut butter required the operator to change out the timer & temperature chart at the beginning of each roast, record the speed setting and temperature reading from the HMI, and record the height of the bed from the measurement gauge at the start (Old Fashion only), then once per shift or after adjustments. CCP #1 for seed butter and bulk tree nuts and seeds required the operator to record the length of the roast cycle and roaster air temperature from the PLC/HMI for each batch. CCP #1 for the oil roasting required

the operator to record the temperature from the equipment thermometer and the roasting time using a stop watch for every roast. The monitoring procedure for the Neo-Pure application for cashews required the process operator to record the rate of sanitizer application from the PLC/HMI screen and the time before drying at the start and end of each production shift. For CCP #2 the production operator was required to conduct a visual inspection to ensure the metal detector was on, the rejection mechanism was working, and the all product passed through the operating metal detector at shift start, every two (2) hours (+/- 30 minutes) during production and at the end of day, and when product was rejected, to examine the rejected product for the presence of metal fragments. The documented monitoring procedure did not detail that the function of the metal detector was checked by passing a ferrous, non ferrous and stainless steel test standard of a specified size through the metal detector at shift start, every two (2) hours (+/- 30 minutes) during production and at the end of day. For CCP #2-A the production operator was responsible to visually ensure that the glass cleaner air and vacuum was on and the all glass jars passed through the operating glass cleaner at shift start, every two (2) hours (+/- 30 minutes) during production and at the end of day, and when defects were found, to clean-out glass jars for the presence of glass fragments and complete the supplier reporting of any defects. The CCP monitoring records were reviewed for the following process/dates: Almond room: 09/27-09/29 & 12/21-12/23, 2021 and 03/15-03/17, 2022; Seed room: 06/09-06/11, 09/20-09/22, 12/22, 12/23 & 12/27, 2021 and 03/15-03/17, 2022; Bulk: 06/07-06/09, 09/07-09/09, 12/20-12/22, 2021 and 03/07-03/09, 2022; and Peanut butter: 06/02-06/04, 09/07-09/09 & 12/02-12/04, 2021 and 03/07-03/09, 2022. The records reviewed were legible and confirmed by those undertaking monitoring activities, verified, readily accessible, retrievable, and securely stored to prevent unauthorized access, loss, damage, and deterioration. The corrective action for a CCP #1 deviation was to place the product on hold, reprocess, if possible or otherwise destroy including any finished product that was found to be implicated, and any equipment that was in direct contact with the underprocessed product was required to be cleaned and sanitized according to the teardown procedures. The corrective action for a CCP #2 deviation, i.e. if the metal detector failed to detect or reject a test standard, was to stop the line and repair the unit, hold all product produced since the last time the metal detector was verified as fully functional, and product disposition determined by QA based on a risk assessment and if metal was found in rejected product, to determine the source of the contamination. The corrective action for CCP #2-A deviation, i.e. the glass cleaner/air/vacuum did not function, was to stop the line and repair the unit, hold all product produced since the last time the glass was verified as fully functional, and product disposition determined by QA based on a risk assessment. The verification activities identified included a review of all processing records and testing results for indicator organisms prior to product release. The documented and approved food safety plans were fully implemented. The annual reassessment of the Dry Roasted Peanuts; Peanut Butter; Seed Butter and Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds was completed. The reassessment of the Tree Nut Butter food safety plan was completed prior to the start-up of the new almond room that had been introduced to the site since the previous recertification audit. The food safety plans were developed to comply with the requirements of the US FDA FSMA Preventive Rules for Human Food Act. 2.4.3.8 - Minor Non Conformance: The methodology used to determine the significance of the potential food safety hazards was not documented to ensure that it was consistently used to assess all potential process hazards.

- 2.4.3.8** The food safety team shall conduct a hazard analysis for every identified hazard to determine which hazards are significant, i.e., their elimination or reduction to an acceptable level is necessary to control food safety. The methodology for determining hazard significance shall be documented and used consistently to assess all potential hazards.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: The methodology used to determine the significance of the potential food safety hazards was not documented to ensure that it was consistently used to assess all potential process hazards.

ROOT CAUSE: Followed the format as outlined in PCQI format and examples from training. Referenced old HACCP forms which did rate hazards when transitioning to PCQI format.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: Add a Food Safety Risk Analysis Matrix (FSRAM) score to each Hazard Analysis step showing justification of our determinations.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Food Safety Risk Assessment Matrix (FSRAM) score added to the hazard analyses of the process steps for each food safety plan.

COMPLETION DATE: 04/29/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

11.2.5 Cleaning and Sanitation

Document #QMS-PLC0012 detailed the requirements of the Equipment Operation Condition & Sanitation Policy. Sanitation Standard Operating Procedures (SSOPs) were documented and a Master Sanitation Schedule (MSS) was developed and maintained for each area. Document #QMS-SPRC0001 was reviewed for the COP tank use. The peanut roaster was wet cleaned after 400,000 pounds of peanuts were processed. All other areas of the facility were dry wiped as required and wet cleaned prior to a product change-over or at pre-determined intervals. The MSS records were reviewed for the Peanut facility for the month of Mar, 2022. A current list and inventory of chemicals approved for use was documented and maintained. An SDS in printed copy and an electronic database were made available to the relevant personnel. Detergents and sanitizers that were required to be mixed for use were correctly mixed according to the manufacturers' instructions, stored in containers that were suitable for use, and clearly identified. Mix concentrations were verified for each COP tank use, daily for Oxywave and ProClean, and weekly for all other detergents and sanitizers. The titration log sheet was reviewed for the week of 02/20-02/24, 2022. The records reviewed indicated the chemicals were used at the recommended concentrations. Suitably equipped clean-out-of-place (COP) areas were provided for cleaning product containers, utensils, and equipment parts. The COP areas and operations were appropriately controlled so they did not interfere with manufacturing operations, equipment, or product. Racks and containers for storing cleaned utensils were provided, when required. Hot rooms were provided for the drying of the COP cleaned containers, utensils, and equipment parts. Cleaning equipment, tools, racks, and other items used in support of the cleaning and sanitizing program were clearly identified, stored, and maintained in a manner that prevented contamination of processing areas, product handling equipment, and storage areas, as well as the tools themselves. Cleaning-in-place (CIP) systems were not used. Pre-operational inspections were conducted following cleaning and sanitation operations to ensure food processing areas, product contact surfaces, equipment, and other essential areas were clean before the start of production. Pre-operational inspections were conducted by qualified QA personnel. Company employed, dedicated sanitation personnel were responsible for the cleaning of the staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas of the facilities and off-site warehouse and were inspected by qualified personnel at a defined frequency to ensure the areas were clean. Visual inspection, ATP swabbing, and microbiological sampling of food contact surfaces were the methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning procedures. Visual inspection and ATP swabbing were conducted after each wet cleaning event. Microbiological sampling of the food contact surfaces was conducted at least annually. The absence of visible food residue on the food contact surfaces, and RLU <150, and a test results of <100 cfu for total plate count (TPC) and/or <10 cfu for coliforms were the acceptable limits for visual inspection, ATP swabbing, and microbiological sampling. 11.2.5.1 - Minor Non Conformance: Several of the monthly cleaning tasks identified for the Peanut Facility Processing Room were not completed and a reason as to why the tasks were not completed was not documented.

11.2.5.1 The methods and responsibility for the effective cleaning of the food handling and processing equipment and environment and storage areas shall be documented and implemented. Consideration shall be given to: i. What is to be cleaned; ii. How it is to be cleaned; iii. When it is to be cleaned; iv. Who is responsible for the cleaning; v. Validation of the cleaning procedures for food contact surfaces (including CIP); vi. Methods used to confirm the correct concentrations of detergents and sanitizers; and vii. The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: Several of the monthly cleaning tasks identified for the Peanut Facility Processing Room were not completed and a reason as to why the tasks were not completed was not documented.

ROOT CAUSE: Form not designed with section or instruction for comments when a task was not completed. Procedure not developed outlining what to do if task not complete.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: 1. Update Equipment Operation Condition & Sanitation Policy - QMS-PLC0012 to including more detail on how we're going to monitor/communicate compliance rates. 2. Create a procedure on on how we're going to monitor/communicate compliance.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Effectiveness of implementation to be verified during the next recertification audit.

COMPLETION DATE: 04/29/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

11.6.4 Storage of Hazardous Chemicals and Toxic Substances

Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances with the potential for food contamination were clearly labeled, included in a current register, and a current SDS was made available to all relevant personnel. Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances were stored in designated areas in a manner that prevented a hazard to finished product or product contact surfaces. Processing utensils and packaging were not observed to be stored in areas used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances. Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances were used according to manufacturers' instructions, controlled to prevent contamination or a hazard to raw and packaging material, work-in progress, finished product, or product contact surfaces, and returned to the appropriate storage areas after use. Daily supplies of chemicals were appropriately managed. Personnel who handled hazardous chemicals and toxic substances were fully trained and provided with first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment (PPE). Empty, obsolete, and unused chemicals were segregated and securely stored prior to collection and disposed of through an approved vendor. Empty chemical containers were not reused, segregated, and securely stored prior to collection, and disposed through an approved vendor. Spillage clean-up instructions and PPE, spillage kits, and cleaning equipment were provided for the containment and clean-up of chemical spills. 11.6.4.2 - Minor Non Conformance: Chemical cabinets used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances and/or the areas in which the chemical cabinets were located were not secure in order to effectively restricted access to the hazardous chemicals and toxic substances to authorized personnel only.

11.6.4.2 Storage of hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be: i. Located in an area with appropriate signage indicating that the area is for hazardous storage; ii. Controlled, lockable, and accessible only by personnel trained in the storage and use of chemicals; iii. Adequately ventilated; iv. Stored where intended and not comingled (e.g., food versus non-food grade); v. Designed such that pesticides, rodenticides, fumigants, and insecticides are stored separately from sanitizers and detergents; and vi. Stored in a manner that prevents a hazard to finished product or product contact surfaces. Processing utensils and packaging shall not be stored in areas used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: Chemical cabinets used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances and/or the areas in which the chemical cabinets were located were not secure in order to effectively restricted access to the hazardous chemicals and toxic substances to authorized personnel only.

ROOT CAUSE: Details on secured storage for chemicals and lubricants were not included in the Chemical Control Policies - QMS-PLC0010, New Chemical & Lubricant Approval - QMS-PRC0041, or Chemical/Lubricant Approval Request - QMS-FORM0089

CORRECTIVE ACTION: 1. Update Chemical Control Policies - QMS-PLC0010 to include details on securing maintenance and production storage cabinets along with maintenance shops. 2. Place temporary locks on cabinets. 3. Install Door Security (PHAB ACCESS) System.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Effectiveness of implementation to be verified during the next recertification audit.

COMPLETION DATE: 04/21/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

11.7.1 High-Risk Processes

The tree nut filling, seed filling, bulk filling, and almond filling rooms in the Main Facility and peanut butter bulk, peanut butter jar, and peanut butter processing rooms in the Peanut Facility were identified as high-risk production areas. Ambient air in high-risk areas was microbiological tested at least annually to confirm that it does not pose a risk to food safety. The test results for the ambient air testing conducted on 03/10/2022 were reviewed. The air samples were evaluated for yeast and mold, all test results were recorded as <20, with the exception of a mold test result for the bulk filling room, which was recorded as 60 cfu/m3. Areas in which high-risk processes were conducted were serviced by personnel dedicated to that function or personnel were required to don a protective outer garment if entering into a raw processing area, additionally personnel in the Peanut facility were required to don protective "booties" over footwear when entering into the low-risk production areas. All personnel were required to wash and sanitize their hands and pass through a dry quat granular "footbath" prior to entering into any high risk area. Product transfer points, with the exception of the seed roaster, were located and designed so they did not compromise the high-risk segregation and minimized the risk of cross-contamination. Major Non Conformance: The design and positioning of the roaster in the seed room was such that the post lethality product was not adequately protected from contamination. The raw seed infeed conveyor and hopper to the roaster were located directly above the outlet and exposed product cooling pans for the roasted product, such that any raw product spilling out of the infeed equipment could potential fall into the roasted seeds. A minor accumulation of raw sesame seed was observed on the cover of the infeed hopper during the audit.

- 11.7.1.1** The processing of high-risk food shall be conducted under controlled conditions, such that sensitive areas, in which the high-risk food has undergone a "kill" step, a "food safety intervention" or is subject to post-process handling, are protected/segregated from other processes, raw materials, or staff who handle raw materials, to ensure cross-contamination is minimized.

RESPONSE: MAJOR

EVIDENCE: The design and positioning of the roaster in the seed room was such that the post lethality product was not adequately protected from contamination. The raw seed infeed conveyor and hopper to the roaster were located directly above the outlet and exposed product cooling pans for the roasted product, such that any raw product spilling out of the infeed equipment could potential fall into the roasted seeds. A minor accumulation of raw sesame seed was observed on the cover of the infeed hopper during the audit.

ROOT CAUSE: Design of roaster and area did not fully assure raw material could not enter the process or packaging area.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: 1. Design a temporary seal around the hopper to prevent any seeds from falling into finished product carts. 2. Add a visual inspection of the hopper for any spillage on the Seed Room - Pre-Op Inspection Form. 3. Add a daily cleaning task to the Master Sanitation Schedule to inspect/clean the top of the raw hopper. 4. Design an enclosure around raw hopper above the roaster to exclude the possibility of raw seeds from entering the finished product stream and providing complete separation from the finished product packaging area.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Effectiveness of implementation to be verified during the next recertification audit.

COMPLETION DATE: 05/01/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

Audit Statements	
SQF Practitioner Name	Name the designated SQF Practitioner RESPONSE: Jacob Rawleigh
SQF Practitioner Email	Email of the designated SQF Practitioner RESPONSE: jake@onceagainnutbutter.com
Opening Meeting	People Present at the Opening Meeting (Please list names and roles in the following format Name: Role separated by commas) RESPONSE: Robert Gelser: President, Larry Filipski: CFO, Mark Brace: GM/QA Director; Dan Pijanowski: Supply Chain Director, Julie Alpert: Director, HR, Benjamin Lorton, Plant Manager - Peanut, Jacob Rawleigh, QA Supervisor, Colin Wilcox: Sanitation Supervisor, Stephen Muir: SQF Lead Auditor
Facility Description	Auditor Description of Facility (Please provide facility description include # of employees, size, production schedule, general layout, and any additional pertinent details) RESPONSE: Once Again Nut Butter was established in 1976. The company operated two (2) manufacturing facilities located in Nunda, NY and an off-site warehouse located in Perry, NY. The Main Facility produced FSC 14 roasted almonds & almond butter, roasted cashews & cashew butter, nut butter, roasted seeds, including sesame and sunflower and seed butter, and boxed nuts, was approximately 32,000 sq. ft. in size and the layout included: dock area, warehouse, storage cooler for raw material, almond roasting room, almond filling room, bulk roasting room (cashew), bulk nut room (for both almond and cashew), seed room (sesames and sunflower) and tree nut room (almond and cashew), two (2) wet rooms for equipment cleaning and a hot room to dry equipment. The facility also equipped with a Neo Pure system for cashew treatment prior to roasting. The Peanut Facility was dedicate to the production of FSC 14 roasted peanuts and peanut butter and spreads, was approximately 40,000 sq. ft. in size and the layout included: raw peanut receiving dock and warehouse, shipping dock area for finished goods and receiving of packaging material, a roaster room, processing room, bulk filling room, jar filling room, a wet room for cleaning, and a hot room for the drying of equipment. The off-site warehouse was approximately 72,000 sq. ft. in size and was used for the storage of raw and packaging material and finished goods. The current Certificate of Registration #103543 issued by Merieux NutriSciences Certification, LLC on May 14, 2021, with an expiry date of June 10, 2022 was valid at the time of the UNANNOUNCED recertification audit. The corrections and corrective actions developed to address the six (6) minor NCs cited during the previous recertification audit were effectively implemented and verified to prevent recurrence.
Closing Meeting	People Present at the Closing Meeting (Please list names and roles in the following format Name: Role separated by commas) RESPONSE: Robert Gelser: President, Larry Filipski: CFO, Mark Brace: GM/QA Director; Dan Pijanowski: Supply Chain Director, Benjamin Lorton: Plant Manager - Peanut, Ryan Nugent: Plant Manager - Main, Jacob Rawleigh, QA Supervisor, Pete Millen: Process Engineer, Stephen Muir: SQF Lead Auditor
Auditor Recommendation	Auditor Recommendation RESPONSE: Maintain certification

2.1.1 Management Responsibility (Mandatory)

Senior site management had prepared and implement a policy statement that complied with the requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing, Ed. 9. The policy statement was endorsed by the signatures of the Company President and General Manager/Quality Assurance Director, displayed in prominent positions, and effectively communicated to all site personnel. Document #QMS-PLC0019 detailed the requirements for Food Safety & Staff Responsibility. The 2022 Food Safety & Quality Goals included; Customer Complaints,

- 2.1.1.1** Senior site management shall prepare and implement a policy statement that outlines at a minimum the commitment of all site management to: i. Supply safe food; ii. Establish and maintain a food safety culture within the site; iii. Establish and continually improve the site's food safety management system; and iv. Comply with customer and regulatory requirements to supply safe food. The policy statement shall be: v. Signed by the senior site manager and displayed in prominent positions; and vi. Effectively communicated to all site personnel in the language(s) understood by all site personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.2** Senior site management shall lead and support a food safety culture within the site that ensures at a minimum: i. The establishment, documentation, and communication to all relevant staff of food safety objectives and performance measures; ii. Adequate resources are available to meet food safety objectives; iii. Food safety practices and all applicable requirements of the SQF System are adopted and maintained; iv. Employees are informed and held accountable for their food safety and regulatory responsibilities; v. Employees are positively encouraged and required to notify management about actual or potential food safety issues; and vi. Employees are empowered to act to resolve food safety issues within their scope of work.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.3** The reporting structure shall identify and describe site personnel with specific responsibilities for tasks within the food safety management system and identify a backup for the absence of key personnel. Job descriptions for the key personnel shall be documented. Site management shall ensure departments and operations are appropriately staffed and organizationally aligned to meet food safety objectives.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.4** Senior site management shall designate a primary and substitute SQF practitioner for each site with responsibility and authority to: i. Oversee the development, implementation, review, and maintenance of the SQF System; ii. Take appropriate action to ensure the integrity of the SQF System; and iii. Communicate to relevant personnel all information essential to ensure the effective implementation and maintenance of the SQF System.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.5** The primary and substitute SQF practitioner shall: i. Be employed by the site; ii. Hold a position of responsibility related to the management of the site's SQF System; iii. Have completed a HACCP training course; iv. Be competent to implement and maintain HACCP based food safety plans; and v. Have an understanding of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing and the requirements to implement and maintain an SQF System relevant to the site's scope of certification

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.6** Senior site management shall ensure the training needs of the site are resourced, implemented, and meet the requirements outlined in system elements 2.9 and that site personnel meet the required competencies to carry out those functions affecting the legality and safety of food products.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.7** Senior site management shall ensure the integrity and continued operation of the food safety system in the event of organizational or personnel changes within the company or associated facilities.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.1.8** Senior site management shall designate defined blackout periods that prevent unannounced re-certification audits from occurring out of season or when the site is not operating for legitimate business reasons. The list of blackout dates and their justification shall be submitted to the certification body a minimum of one (1) month before the sixty (60) day re-certification window for the agreed-upon unannounced audit.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.1.2 Management Review (Mandatory)

The SQF System was reviewed by senior site management at least annually. The annual senior site management review of the SQF System was completed on 02/25/2022. A schedule of weekly site staff meetings was utilized by the SQF practitioners to update senior site management on matters impacting the implementation and maintenance of the SQF System.

- 2.1.2.1** The SQF System shall be reviewed by senior site management at least annually and include: i. Changes to food safety management system documentation (policies, procedures, specifications, food safety plan); ii. Food safety culture performance; iii. Food safety objectives and performance measures; iv. Corrective and preventative actions and trends in findings from internal and external audits, customer complaints, and verification and validation activities; v. Hazard and risk management system; and vi. Follow-up action items from previous management reviews. Records of all management reviews and updates shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE: .

- 2.1.2.2** The SQF practitioner(s) shall update senior site management on at least a monthly basis on matters impacting the implementation and maintenance of the SQF System. The updates and management responses shall be documented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.1.3 Complaint Management (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PRC0058 detailed the requirements for Complaint Management. Adverse trends of customer complaint data were investigated and analyzed and the root cause established by personnel knowledgeable about the incidents. An analysis of the complaint data by month and by category was completed at least annually. The 2021 trend analysis by category was reviewed. A total of 293 complaints were recorded, the top three (3) complaint categories were, taste (76) , foreign material (74) , and texture (66). Corrective and preventative action were implemented based on the seriousness of the incident and the root cause analysis. Records of customer complaints, their investigation, and resolution were appropriately maintained.

- 2.1.3.1** The methods and responsibility for handling, investigating, and resolving food safety complaints from commercial customers, consumers, and authorities, arising from products manufactured or handled on-site or co-manufactured, shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.3.2** Adverse trends of customer complaint data shall be investigated and analyzed and the root cause established by personnel knowledgeable about the incidents.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.1.3.3** Corrective and preventative action shall be implemented based on the seriousness of the incident and the root cause analysis as outlined in 2.5.3. Records of customer complaints, their investigation, and resolution shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.2.1 Food Safety Management System (Mandatory)

The food safety management system was documented and maintained in an electronic format. The food safety plans, GMPs and other aspects of the SQF System were required to be reviewed, updated, and communicated as needed or when any change was implemented that had an impact on the site's ability to deliver safe food.

- 2.2.1.1** The methods and procedures the site uses to meet the requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing shall be maintained in electronic and/or hard copy documentation. They will be made available to relevant staff and include: i. A summary of the organization's food safety policies and the methods it will apply to meet the requirements of this standard; ii. The food safety policy statement and organization chart; iii. The processes and products included in the scope of certification; iv. Food safety regulations that apply to the manufacturing site and the country(ies) of sale (if known); v. Raw material, ingredient, packaging, and finished product specifications; vi. Food safety procedures, prerequisite programs, food safety plans; vii. Process controls that impact product safety; and viii. Other documentation necessary to support the development, implementation, maintenance, and control of the SQF System.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.2.1.2** Food safety plans, Good Manufacturing Practices, and all relevant aspects of the SQF System shall be reviewed, updated, and communicated as needed when any changes implemented have an impact on the site's ability to deliver safe food. All changes to food safety plans, Good Manufacturing Practices, and other aspects of the SQF System shall be validated or justified prior to their implementation. The reasons for the change shall be documented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.2.2 Document Control (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PRC0001 detailed the requirements of the Document Control Procedure. Based on the documents reviewed, current SQF System documents and amendments to documents were maintained.

- 2.2.2.1** The methods and responsibility for maintaining document control and ensuring staff have access to current requirements and instructions shall be documented and implemented. Current SQF System documents and amendments to documents shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.2.3 Records (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0055 detailed the requirements of the Document and Records Management - Change and Retention Policy. All records critical to the management of product safety, regulatory compliance, quality and SQF compliance were retained for a minimum of five (5) years. Based on the records reviewed, records that demonstrated inspections, analyses, and other essential activities had been completed were legible, confirmed by those undertaking monitoring activities, verified, when applicable, and were readily accessible, retrievable, and securely stored to prevent unauthorized access, loss, damage, and deterioration.

- 2.2.3.1** The methods, frequency, and responsibility for verifying, maintaining, and retaining records shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.2.3.2** All records shall be legible and confirmed by those undertaking monitoring activities that demonstrate inspections, analyses, and other essential activities that have been completed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.2.3.3** Records shall be readily accessible, retrievable, and securely stored to prevent unauthorized access, loss, damage, and deterioration. Retention periods shall be in accordance with customer, legal, and regulatory requirements, at minimum the product shelf-life or established by the site if no shelf-life exists.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.3.1 Specification, Formulation and Realization

Document #QMS-Chart0017 detailed the Product Development Flow that included, creativity, concept definition, project team and responsibilities, concept development testing & finalizing concept, product launch logistics, and management of product life cycle. No new product had been introduced to the facilities since the previous recertification audit. Product formulations and manufacturing processes for products included in the scope of certification were reviewed when there were changes in materials, ingredients, or equipment. The use of a five (5)lb pail was introduced for all butters produced at the Main and Peanut facilities since the previous recertification audit. The process flows for all new and existing manufacturing processes were designed to ensure that product was manufactured according to approved product formulations.

- 2.3.1.1** The methods and responsibility for designing and developing new product formulations and converting product concepts to commercial realization shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.1.2** New product formulations, manufacturing processes, and the fulfillment of product requirements shall be established, validated, and verified by site trials and product testing as required to ensure product safety. Product formulations shall be developed by authorized persons to ensure that they meet the intended use. Where necessary, shelf life trials shall be conducted to validate and verify a new product's: i. Pre-consumer handling and storage requirements, including the establishment of "use by," "best before dates," or equivalent terminology; ii. Microbiological criteria, where applicable; and iii. Consumer preparation, where applicable, and storage and handling requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.1.3** A food safety plan shall be validated and verified by the site food safety team for each new product and its associated process through conversion to commercial production and distribution or where a change to ingredients, process, or packaging occurs that may impact food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.3.1.4	Product formulations and manufacturing processes for products included in the scope of certification shall be reviewed when there are changes in materials, ingredients, or equipment. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.1.5	The process flows for all new and existing manufacturing processes shall be designed to ensure that product is manufactured according to approved product formulations and to prevent cross-contamination. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.1.6	Records of product design, formulations, label compliance, process flows, shelf life trials, and approvals for all new and existing products shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2	Specifications (Raw Material, Packaging, Finished Product and Services) All raw materials, including ingredients and packaging were required to comply with the relevant specification and legislation in the country of manufacture and countries of destination. Raw materials, ingredients or packaging were not received from other sites under the same corporate ownership. A letter of guarantee (LOG) issued by the supplier and a pasteurization certificate for raw almonds were used to ensure product safety was not compromised and the received materials were fit for their intended purpose. Verification of packaging include confirmation that direct food contact packaging met either regulatory acceptance and/or the approval criteria. The specifications were reviewed for the raw materials identified in the product trace exercise that included, organic peanuts, supplied by Peanut Import & Distribution, and plastic bucket and lid supplied by Berlin. Approved raw materials suppliers were required to notify the site's Quality department thirty (30) days in advance of changes in product composition that could impact product formulation. The QA Supervisor was the person responsible to ensure finished product labels were accurate and complied with the relevant legislation. The finished product label and product specification were reviewed of item #OV3243, Organic Peanut Butter Smooth, 35 pounds identified in the product trace exercise. Description of services for contract service providers that had an impact on product safety were documented, current, included a full description of the services to be provided, and detailed relevant training requirements of all contract personnel required to visit the site. Current lists of the raw material, finished product and contract service provider specifications were documented and maintained. Raw material specifications was maintained in a ReposiTrak database.
2.3.2.1	The methods and responsibility for developing, managing, and approving raw material, finished product, and packaging specifications shall be documented. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.2	Specifications for all raw materials and packaging, including, but not limited to, ingredients, additives, hazardous chemicals, processing aids, and packaging that impact finished product safety shall be documented and kept current. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.3	All raw materials, packaging, and ingredients, including those received from other sites under the same corporate ownership, shall comply with specifications and with the relevant legislation in the country of manufacture and country(ies) of destination if known. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.4	Raw materials, packaging, and ingredients shall be validated to ensure product safety is not compromised and the material is fit for its intended purpose. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.5	Site management shall require approved raw materials suppliers to notify the site of changes in product composition that could have an impact on product formulation (e.g., protein content, moisture, amino acid profiles, contaminant levels, allergens, and/or other parameters that may vary by crop or by season). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.6	Verification of packaging shall include a certification of all packaging that comes into direct contact with food meets either regulatory acceptance or approval criteria. Documentation shall either be in the form of a declaration of continued guarantee of compliance, a certificate of conformance, or a certificate from the applicable regulatory agency. In the absence of a certificate of conformance, certificate of analysis, or letter of guarantee, analyses to confirm the absence of potential chemical migration from the packaging to the food contents shall be conducted and records maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.7	Finished product labels shall be accurate, comply with the relevant legislation, and be approved by qualified company personnel. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.3.2.8	Description of services for contract service providers that have an impact on product safety shall be documented, current, include a full description of the services to be provided, and detail relevant training requirements of all contract personnel.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.9	Finished product specifications shall be documented, current, approved by the site and its customer, accessible to relevant staff, and shall include, where applicable: i. Microbiological, chemical, and physical limits; ii. Composition to meet label claims; iii. Labeling and packaging requirements; and iv. Storage conditions.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.2.10	Specifications for raw materials and packaging, chemicals, processing aids, contract services, and finished products shall be reviewed as changes occur that impact product safety. Records of reviews shall be maintained. A list of all the above specifications shall be maintained and kept current.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.3	Contract Manufacturers Document #QMS-PLC0031 detailed the methods and responsibility for ensuring all agreements with contract manufacturers relating to food safety, customer product requirements, their realization, and delivery were documented and implemented. The site utilized the service of a contract manufacturer to produce Organic Amore Spread including Almond with Cocoa & Milk, Hazelnut with Cocoa & milk, Almond with White Cocoa Butter, Hazelnut with White Cocoa Butter and Organic Almond Butter - Blanched-Creamy. The contract manufacturer was audited by the company and was certified to the IFS FOOD Version 7, October 2020 Higher Level. The current certificate had an expiry date of 23.01.2023. The site utilized the services of 3rd party storage and distribution business. The 3rd party warehouse was certified to the SQF Food Safety Code: Storage and Distribution. Records of audits, contracts, and changes to contractual agreements and their approvals were maintained.
2.3.3.1	The methods and responsibility for ensuring all agreements with contract manufacturers relating to food safety, customer product requirements, their realization, and delivery shall be documented and implemented.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.3.2	The site shall establish a method to determine the food safety risk level of contract manufactured product and shall document the risk. The site shall ensure that: i. Products and processes of co-manufacturers that are considered high-risk have undergone an audit by the site or third-party agency to confirm compliance with the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing and regulatory and customer requirements; ii. Products and processes of co-manufacturers that are considered low-risk meet the requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing, or other GFSI benchmarked certification programs, and regulatory and customer requirements; and iii. Changes to contractual agreements are approved by both parties and communicated to relevant personnel.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.3.3	Contractual agreements with third party storage and distribution businesses shall include requirements relating to customer product requirements and compliance with clause 2.3.3.2 of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing. Contractual agreements shall be approved by both parties and communicated to relevant personnel. The site shall verify compliance with the SQF Code and ensure that customer and regulatory requirements are being met at all times.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.3.3.4	Records of audits, contracts, and changes to contractual agreements and their approvals shall be maintained.
	RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.3.4 Approved Supplier Program (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0031 detailed the requirements of the Collective Supplier General Requirements Policy. A current list of approved suppliers was documented and maintained. The supplier contact details were accessible through the use of the (No Suggestions) database. Supplier approval was generally based on a pre-audit questionnaire that the supplier was required to complete, a thorough review of the required supplier documentation, the result of a risk based supplier assessment, the signed approval of the material specification by the company and the supplier, and an ongoing performance review. Document #QMS-LIST0028 detailed the required supplier documentation which included, product specification, non GMO statement, allergen control program/declaration, allergen form/matrix, nanotechnology, irradiation and PPO statement, use of processing aids, Kosher certificate, Organic certificate, FDA Food Facility registration number, HACCP plan (flow diagram and CCP(s) at a minimum), 3rd party food safety audit with CAs, recall plan, contact list, SDS, LOG, pesticide/heavy metal testing results, flavor declaration for USA and Canada, at a minimum, flavor extract source, IP certification, vegan form, CTPAT, and food safety survey/questionnaire, where applicable. All incoming materials were visually inspected at receipt. A LOG issued by the supplier was required for all raw materials. A pasteurization certificate was required for each lot of pasteurized almonds received at the site. No raw materials, ingredients, processing aids or packaging had been received from a non approved supplier since the previous recertification audit. Raw materials, ingredients, and packaging were not received from other sites under the same corporate ownership. Supplier audits were based on risk and were conducted by individuals knowledgeable of applicable regulatory and food safety requirements and trained in auditing techniques. Supplier audits, when required, were conducted by the General Manager/ QA Director.

- 2.3.4.1** The responsibility and procedure for selecting, evaluating, approving, and monitoring an approved supplier shall be documented and implemented. A current record of approved suppliers, receiving inspections, and supplier audits shall be maintained. Code Amendment #2 Approved supplier registers shall include supplier contact details. All approved and emergency suppliers shall be registered.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.4.2** The approved supplier program shall be based on the past performance of a supplier and the risk level of the raw materials, ingredients, processing aids, packaging, and services supplied, and shall contain at a minimum: i. Agreed specifications (refer to 2.3.2); ii. Reference to the level of risk applied to raw materials, ingredients, packaging, and services from the approved supplier; iii. A summary of the food safety controls implemented by the approved supplier; iv. Methods for granting approved supplier status; v. Methods and frequency of monitoring approved suppliers; vi. Details of the certificates of conformance, if required; and vii. Methods and frequency of reviewing approved supplier performance and status.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.4.3** Verification of raw materials shall include certificates of conformance, certificates of analysis, or sampling, and testing. The verification frequency shall be identified by the site.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.4.4** The receipt of raw materials, ingredients, processing aids, and packaging from nonapproved suppliers shall be acceptable only in an emergency situation and provided a receiving inspection or analysis is conducted and recorded before use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.4.5** Raw materials, ingredients, and packaging received from other sites under the same corporate ownership shall be subject to the same specification requirements (refer to 2.3.2), approved supplier requirements, and receiving inspections as all other material providers.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.3.4.6** Supplier audits shall be based on risk (as determined in 2.3.4.2) and shall be conducted by individuals knowledgeable of applicable regulatory and food safety requirements and trained in auditing techniques.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.1 Food Legislation (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0022 detailed the relevant legislative requirements that the site was required to comply with. No regulatory warning/event had been issued to/occurred at the company since the previous recertification audit. Document #QMS-PRC0054 detailed the methods and responsibility for ensuring the site was kept informed of changes to relevant legislation, scientific and technical developments, emerging food safety issues, and relevant industry codes of practice.

- 2.4.1.1** The site shall ensure that at the time of delivery to customers finished products shall comply with food safety legislation applicable in the country of manufacture and sale. This includes compliance with legislative requirements applicable to maximum residue limits, food safety, packaging, product description, net weights, nutritional, allergen, and additive labeling, labeling of identity preserved foods, any other criteria listed under food legislation, and to relevant established industry codes of practice.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.1.2** The methods and responsibility for ensuring the site is kept informed of changes to relevant legislation, scientific and technical developments, emerging food safety issues, and relevant industry codes of practice shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.1.3** SQFI and the certification body shall be notified in writing within twenty-four (24) hours as a result of a regulatory warning or event. Notification to SQFI shall be by email to foodsafetycrisis@sqfi.com.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.2 Good Manufacturing Practices (Mandatory)

The Good Manufacturing Practices (GMPs) described in module 11 of Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing, Edition 9 were appropriately applied. The site had not requested nor been granted an exemption for any of the GMP requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code. The GMPs applicable to the scope of certification that outlined how food safety was controlled and assured were documented and implemented.

- 2.4.2.1** The site shall ensure the applicable Good Manufacturing Practices described in Module 11 of this Food Safety Code are applied or exempted according to a written risk analysis outlining the justification for exemption or evidence of the effectiveness of alternative control measures that ensure food safety is not compromised.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.2.2** The Good Manufacturing Practices applicable to the scope of certification outlining how food safety is controlled and assured shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.3 Food Safety Plan (Mandatory)

A multidisciplinary team that included the SQF practitioners and site personnel with technical, production, and engineering knowledge of the relevant raw materials, packaging, processing aids, products, and associated processes was responsible for the development and maintenance of five (5) HACCP-based food safety plans including; Dry Roasted Peanuts; Peanut Butter; Tree Nut Butter; Seed Butter, and Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds. A product description that detailed the following; Product Name(s); Process Type; Important Food Safety Characteristics; Ingredients; Packaging; Intended Use; Intended Consumer; Shelf Life; Labeling Instructions (related to food safety); and Storage and Distribution was documented for each food safety plan. The dry roasted peanuts including whole peanuts, peanut splits and granulated peanuts had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of five (5) months from date of manufacture. The peanut butter and spreads contained varying sizes of peanut particulates depending on variety, some varieties were flavored, fortified or contained additional particulates. The peanut butter and spreads had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of twelve (12) to eighteen (18) months from date of manufacture, depending on variety. The tree nut butter, including almond and cashew butters contained varying sizes of nut particulates depending on variety, some varieties were flavored, fortified or contained additional particulates, had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of twelve (12) to eighteen (18) months from date of manufacture, depending on variety. The seed butters, including sesame, sunflower and Tahini may contain oils, sugar, flavorings or salt, had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of twelve (12) months from date of manufacture, depending on variety. Product labels complied with the allergen labeling requirements, peanuts, almond, cashews, sesame seed, and sunflower were listed in the ingredient declaration. For almond and cashew an allergen warning statement "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, sesame seeds and on equipment that processes other tree nuts, for sunflower a "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, tree nuts and on equipment that processes sesame", and for sesame "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, and tree nuts" was used. The bulk packed whole nuts, including almonds, Tamari almonds, cashews and bulk packaged seeds had a low water activity ($A_w < 0.85$), were a ready-to-eat product or could be used as an ingredients and had a shelf life of five (5) months from date of manufacture. The intended use of the peanut, peanut butter and spreads, tree nut butter, seed butters, and bulk packed whole nuts was as a ready-to-eat products or an ingredient. The intended consumer was the general public, food manufacturers and restaurants. Appropriately detailed flow diagrams were documented for the following processes; Almond room; Boxed Nut and Seeds; Seed room; Bulk room - Almond; Bulk room - Cashew; Main facility - Receiving & Storage; Main Facility - Squeeze pack; Peanut Butter (PB) HACCP flow; PB facility - Receiving & Storage; PB Facility - Squeeze pack; PB Facility - Boxed peanuts; and Rework. The biological, chemical, physical food safety hazards that could reasonably be expected to occur at each step in the processes, including raw materials and other inputs were identified and documented. A hazard analysis was completed and reviewed for the following; raw materials, almond room, boxed peanuts, boxed tree nuts, bulk room - almond butter, bulk room - cashew butter, PB facility, receiving and storage, rework, seed room, and tree nut room. The raw material analysis included an evaluation of likelihood and severity to determine the significance of the potential hazards identified. The control measures that were applied to all significant hazards were identified and documented, including Supply Chain, Sanitation and Allergen preventive controls (PCs). The Supply Chain PCs were identified for; Labels - sourced from approved suppliers and the supplier to maintain only the current version for each label in their system; Allergens - ingredients sourced from approved suppliers; Aflatoxin - raw material sourced from only approved suppliers who sort to remove moldy nuts/seeds; Unapproved pesticides - sourced from approved suppliers who monitor growers; Foreign material - raw materials sourced from approved suppliers who utilize foreign material control methods; and Pathogenic bacteria - almonds pasteurized (5 log reduction) before delivery. The Sanitation PC

were identified for zoning and related GMP control; cleaning and sanitation; and microbiological verification of the sanitation practices. The Allergen PC was identified for the nut receiving process step and code/label/band process steps, undeclared allergens was the significant chemical food safety hazard controlled, and the correct ingredient and allergen information printed on the labels applied to the raw material and finished product were the critical criteria. Three (3) process preventive controls/critical control points (PPCs/CCPs) were identified as an outcome of the hazard analyses which included; CCP #1- identified for the thermal process/pathogen reduction process step, including dry roasting, oil roasting, and the use of the Neo-Pure sanitizing solution for cashews; CCP #2 - for the metal detection process step; and CCP #2-A - for the glass container cleaning/air rinsing process step. CCP #1 - dry roasting and CCP #2 - metal detection were applicable to the dry roasted peanuts FSP, CCP #1 - bulk nut roasting, CCP #2 - metal detection, and CCP #2-A - glass container cleaning were applicable to the Peanut Butter FSP, CCP #2 - metal detection and CCP #2-A - glass container cleaning were applicable to the Tree Nut Butter FSP, CCP #1 - seed roasting, CCP #2 - metal detection, and CCP #2-A - glass container cleaning were applicable to the Seed Butter FSP, and CCP #1 - oil roasting and/or dry roasting and CCP #2 - metal detection were applicable to the Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds FSP. The use of the Neo-Pure sanitizing solution was detailed as a process preventive control in the cashew room but not as a CCP in the Nut Butter CCP determination documentation. Non sporeforming pathogens such as Salmonella was the significant biological food safety hazard controlled by CCP #1. For the dry roasted peanut and peanut butter food safety plans, the critical limits for old fashion peanuts included; start up time $\geq$ 25 minutes at a temperature $\geq$ 320 deg F, roast time $\geq$ 20 minutes at a temperature $\geq$ 305 deg F, and a bed depth 22 minutes at a temperature $\geq$ 295 deg F, and a bed depth 30 minutes at 300 deg F for sunflower seeds and a roast time of $\geq$ 35 minutes at 290 deg F for sesame seeds; for the bulk tree nuts and seeds food safety plan, the critical limits were a minimum oil temperature of 350 deg F and a minimum roast time of four (4) minutes and fifty one (51) seconds; and for the Neo-Pure sanitizer application for cashews, the critical limits were a minimum application rate of 80ml/kg and a minimum hold time of ten (10) minutes. Metal inclusion was the significant physical food safety hazard controlled by CCP #2 and the critical limits were a metal detector in place and operating to standard and no metal fragments that would cause injury or a choking hazard. Glass inclusion was the significant physical food safety hazard controlled by CCP #2-A, and the critical limits included, a glass cleaner in place and operating to standard and no glass fragments that would cause injury or a choking hazard. A monitoring procedure that detailed the "What, How, Frequency and Who" was documented for each CCP. CCP #1 for peanuts and peanut butter required the operator to change out the timer & temperature chart at the beginning of each roast, record the speed setting and temperature reading from the HMI, and record the height of the bed from the measurement gauge at the start (Old Fashion only), then once per shift or after adjustments. CCP #1 for seed butter and bulk tree nuts and seeds required the operator to record the length of the roast cycle and roaster air temperature from the PLC/HMI for each batch. CCP #1 for the oil roasting required the operator to record the temperature from the equipment thermometer and the roasting time using a stop watch for every roast. The monitoring procedure for the Neo-Pure application for cashews required the process operator to record the rate of sanitizer application from the PLC/HMI screen and the time before drying at the start and end of each production shift. For CCP #2 the production operator was required to conduct a visual inspection to ensure the metal detector was on, the rejection mechanism was working, and the all product passed through the operating metal detector at shift start, every two (2) hours (+/- 30 minutes) during production and at the end of day, and when product was rejected, to examine the rejected product for the presence of metal fragments. The documented monitoring procedure did not detail that the function of the metal detector was checked by passing a ferrous, non ferrous and stainless steel test standard of a specified size through the metal detector at shift start, every two (2) hours (+/- 30 minutes) during production and at the end of day. For CCP #2-A the production operator was responsible to visually ensure that the glass cleaner air and vacuum was on and the all glass jars passed through the operating glass cleaner at shift start, every two (2) hours (+/- 30 minutes) during production and at the end of day, and when defects were found, to clean-out glass jars for the presence of glass fragments and complete the supplier reporting of any defects. The CCP monitoring records were reviewed for the following process/dates: Almond room: 09/27-09/29 & 12/21-12/23, 2021 and 03/15-03/17, 2022; Seed room: 06/09-06/11, 09/20-09/22, 12/22, 12/23 & 12/27, 2021 and 03/15-03/17, 2022; Bulk: 06/07-06/09, 09/07-09/09, 12/20-12/22, 2021 and 03/07-03/09, 2022; and Peanut butter: 06/02-06/04, 09/07-09/09 & 12/02-12/04, 2021 and 03/07-03/09, 2022. The records reviewed were legible and confirmed by those undertaking monitoring activities, verified, readily accessible, retrievable, and securely stored to prevent unauthorized access, loss, damage, and deterioration. The corrective action for a CCP #1 deviation was to place the product on hold, reprocess, if possible or otherwise destroy including any finished product that was found to be implicated, and any equipment that was in direct contact with the underprocessed product was required to be cleaned and sanitized according to the teardown procedures. The corrective action for a CCP #2 deviation, i.e. if the metal detector failed to detect or reject a test standard, was to stop the line and repair the unit, hold all product produced since the last time the metal detector was verified as fully functional, and product disposition determined by QA based on a risk assessment and if metal was found in rejected product, to determine the source of the contamination. The corrective action for CCP #2-A deviation, i.e. the glass cleaner/air/vacuum did not function, was to stop the line and repair the unit, hold all product produced since the last time the glass was verified as fully functional, and product disposition determined by QA based on a risk assessment. The verification activities identified included a review of all processing records and testing results for indicator organisms prior to product release. The documented and approved food safety plans were fully implemented. The annual reassessment of the Dry Roasted Peanuts; Peanut Butter; Seed Butter and Bulk Tree Nuts & Seeds was completed. The reassessment of the Tree Nut Butter food safety plan was completed prior to the start-up of the new almond room that had been introduced to the site since the previous recertification audit. The food safety plans were developed to comply with the requirements of the US FDA FSMA Preventive Rules for Human Food Act. 2.4.3.8 - Minor Non Conformance: The methodology used to determine the significance of the potential food safety hazards was not documented to ensure that it was consistently used to assess all potential process hazards.

- 2.4.3.1** A food safety plan shall be prepared in accordance with the twelve steps identified in the Codex Alimentarius Commission HACCP guidelines. The food safety plan shall be effectively implemented and maintained and shall outline how the site controls and assures food safety of the products or product groups included in the scope of the SQF certification and their associated processes. More than one HACCP food safety plan may be required to cover all products included in the scope of certification.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.3.2	The food safety plan or plans shall be developed and maintained by a multidisciplinary team that includes the SQF practitioner and those site personnel with technical, production, and engineering knowledge of the relevant raw materials, packaging, processing aids, products, and associated processes. Where the relevant expertise is not available on-site, advice may be obtained from other sources to assist the food safety team. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.3	The scope of each food safety plan shall be developed and documented including the start and endpoints of the processes under consideration and all relevant inputs and outputs. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.4	Product descriptions shall be developed and documented for all products included in the scope of the food safety plans. The descriptions shall reference the finished product specifications (refer to 2.3.2.9) plus any additional information relevant to product safety, such as pH, water activity, composition, and/or storage conditions. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.5	The intended use of each product shall be determined and documented by the food safety team. This shall include target consumer groups, the potential for consumption by vulnerable groups of the population, requirements for further processing if applicable, and potential alternative uses of the product. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.6	The food safety team shall develop and document a flow diagram covering the scope of each food safety plan. The flow diagram shall include every step in the process, all raw materials, packaging, service inputs (e.g., water, steam, gasses as applicable), scheduled process delays, and all process outputs including waste and rework. Each flow diagram shall be confirmed by the food safety team to cover all stages and hours of operation. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.7	The food safety team shall identify and document all food safety hazards that can reasonably be expected to occur at each step in the processes, including raw materials and other inputs. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.8	The food safety team shall conduct a hazard analysis for every identified hazard to determine which hazards are significant, i.e., their elimination or reduction to an acceptable level is necessary to control food safety. The methodology for determining hazard significance shall be documented and used consistently to assess all potential hazards. RESPONSE: MINOR EVIDENCE: The methodology used to determine the significance of the potential food safety hazards was not documented to ensure that it was consistently used to assess all potential process hazards. ROOT CAUSE: Followed the format as outlined in PCQI format and examples from training. Referenced old HACCP forms which did rate hazards when transitioning to PCQI format. CORRECTIVE ACTION: Add a Food Safety Risk Analysis Matrix (FSRAM) score to each Hazard Analysis step showing justification of our determinations. VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Food Safety Risk Assessment Matrix (FSRAM) score added to the hazard analyses of the process steps for each food safety plan. COMPLETION DATE: 04/29/2022 CLOSEOUT DATE: 05/03/2022
2.4.3.9	The food safety team shall determine and document the control measures that must be applied to all significant hazards. More than one control measure may be required to control an identified hazard, and more than one significant hazard may be controlled by a specific control measure. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.10	Based on the results of the hazard analysis (refer to 2.4.3.8), the food safety team shall identify the steps in the process where control must be applied to eliminate a significant hazard or reduce it to an acceptable level (i.e., a critical control point or CCP). In instances where a significant hazard has been identified at a step in the process, but no control measure exists, the food safety team shall modify the process to include an appropriate control measure. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.3.11	For each identified CCP, the food safety team shall identify and document the limits that separate safe from unsafe product (critical limits). The food safety team shall validate all of the critical limits to ensure the level of control of the identified food safety hazard(s) and that all critical limits and control measures individually or in combination effectively provide the level of control required (refer to 2.5.2.1). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.12	The food safety team shall develop and document procedures to monitor CCPs to ensure they remain within the established limits (refer to 2.4.3.11). Monitoring procedures shall identify the personnel assigned to conduct monitoring, the sampling and test methods, and the test frequency. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.13	The food safety team shall develop and document deviation procedures that identify the disposition of affected product when monitoring indicates a loss of control at a CCP. The procedures shall also prescribe actions to correct the process step to prevent recurrence of the safety failure. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.14	The documented and approved food safety plan(s) shall be implemented in full. The effective implementation shall be monitored by the food safety team, and a full review of the documented and implemented plans shall be conducted at least annually, or when changes to the process, equipment, inputs, or other changes affecting product safety occur. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.15	Procedures shall be in place to verify that critical control points are effectively monitored and appropriate corrective actions are applied. Implemented food safety plans shall be verified as part of SQF System verification (refer to 2.5). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.16	Critical control point monitoring, corrective action, and verification records shall be maintained and appropriately used. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.3.17	Where food safety regulations in the country of production and destination (if known) prescribe a food safety control methodology other than the Codex Alimentarius Commission HACCP guidelines, the food safety team shall implement food safety plans that meet both Codex and food regulatory requirements. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.4	Product Sampling, Inspection and Analysis Raw material sampling and testing was limited to aflatoxin testing for the raw peanuts and pathogen testing to verify the effectiveness of the pasteurization of the raw almonds. In-process product testing included moisture, color, and grind size, removal torque for the butters packaged in glass jars, and weight checks. Finished product testing included, free fatty acid (FFA), color, moisture, aerobic plate count (APC), coliforms, E. coli, yeast, mold, Staphylococcus aureus, Salmonella, Listeria monocytogenes, and aflatoxin. The site was equipped with three (3) laboratories that conducted product testing and analysis including FFA, aflatoxin, color, moisture, peroxide value (PV), and grind size. No microbiological analyses were conducted on-site. A proficiency testing program for aflatoxin testing had been developed and implemented in conjunction with Neogen Corporation on a quarterly frequency. The Aflatoxin PT Program - February 2022 Official Report was made available for review. Product analyses were conducted to nationally recognized methods or company requirements, or alternative methods that were validated as equivalent to the nationally recognized methods. A source of bio-hazardous waste that required specialized handling and disposal was not generated by the testing and analyses conducted in the on-site laboratories. External laboratories used to conduct input, environmental, or product analyses and testing were required to be accredited to ISO/IEC 17025, or an equivalent international standard, and verified to be included on the site's contract service specifications list. Retention sample programs had been developed and established for raw materials (nuts and seeds) and finished product. Raw material samples were retained for six (6) months after receipt and finished product samples were retained for six (6) after the stated shelf life. Retention samples were stored according to the typical storage conditions for the product. The nut and seeds and nut and seed butters were ambient temperature, shelf stable products.
2.4.4.1	The methods, responsibility, and criteria for sampling, inspecting, and/or analyzing raw materials, work-in-progress, and finished product shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure that inspections and analyses are completed at regular intervals as required and to agreed specifications and legal requirements. Sampling and testing shall be representative of the process batch and ensure that process controls are maintained to meet specification and formulation. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.4.2	Product analyses shall be conducted to nationally recognized methods or company requirements, or alternative methods that are validated as equivalent to the nationally recognized methods. Where internal laboratories are used to conduct input, environmental, or product analyses, sampling and testing methods shall be in accordance with the applicable requirements of ISO/IEC 17025, including annual proficiency testing for staff conducting analyses. External laboratories shall be accredited to ISO/IEC 17025, or an equivalent international standard, and included on the site's contract service specifications list (refer to 2.3.2.11). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.4.3	On-site laboratories conducting chemical and microbiological analyses that may pose a risk to product safety shall be located separate from any food processing or handling activity and designed to limit access only to authorized personnel. Signage shall be displayed identifying the laboratory area as a restricted area, accessible only by authorized personnel. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.4.4	Provisions shall be made to isolate and contain all hazardous laboratory waste held on the premises and manage it separately from food waste. Laboratory waste outlets shall at a minimum be downstream of drains that service food processing and handling areas. RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE
2.4.4.5	Retention samples, if required by customers or regulations, shall be stored according to the typical storage conditions for the product and maintained for the stated shelflife of the product. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.4.6	Records of all inspections and analyses shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.5	Non-conforming Materials and Product Document #QMS-PRC0046 detailed the requirements of the Hold Procedure for Non Conforming Products. Non conforming raw and packaging materials, WIP, and finished goods were physically identified and quarantined and electronically held in a hold warehouse location in the SAGE100 inventory management system. Raw Material Holds and Finished Product Holds spreadsheets were used to detailed the handling, corrective action, or disposal of nonconforming materials or product were maintained.
2.4.5.1	The responsibility and methods outlining how to handle non-conforming product, raw material, ingredient, work-in-progress, or packaging, which is detected during receipt, storage, processing, handling, or delivery, shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure: i. Non-conforming product is quarantined, identified, handled, and/or disposed of in a manner that minimizes the risk of inadvertent use, improper use, or risk to the integrity of finished product; and ii. All relevant personnel are aware of the organization's quarantine and release requirements applicable to product placed under quarantine status. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.5.2	Quarantine records and records of the handling, corrective action, or disposal of nonconforming materials or product shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.4.6	Product Rework Document #QMS-PLC0042 detailed the requirements of the Rework Policy. Rework conducted at the facilities was limited to the re-packaging of product.
2.4.6.1	The responsibility and methods outlining how ingredients, packaging, or products are reworked shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure: i. Reworking operations are overseen by qualified personnel; ii. Reworked product is clearly identified and traceable; iii. Reworked product is processed in accordance with the site's food safety plan; iv. Each batch of reworked product is inspected or analyzed as required before release; v. Inspections and analyses conform to the requirements outlined in element 2.4.4.1; vi. Release of reworked product conforms to element 2.4.7; and vii. Reworked product does not affect the safety or integrity of the finished product. Records of all reworking operations shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.7 Product Release (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PRC0063 detailed the requirements for Product Release. A positive release procedure was used. Record review and inspection and analysis requirements were required to be completed and reviewed and the product verified to meet all applicable specification requirements before it was released by the QA department for delivery to the customer. Records of the product release were appropriately maintained. The release procedure included confirmation that product labels complied with the food legislation that applicable in the country of manufacture and the countries of sale. Product was exported to Japan.

- 2.4.7.1** The responsibility and methods for releasing products shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure the product is released by authorized personnel, and only after all inspections and analyses are successfully completed and documented to verify legislative and other established food safety controls have been met. Records of all product releases shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.7.2** Product release shall include a procedure to confirm that product labels comply with the food legislation that applies in the country of manufacture and the country(ies) of use or sale if known (refer to 2.4.1.1). If product is packaged and distributed in bulk or unlabeled, product information shall be made available to inform customers and/or consumers of the requirements for its safe use.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.7.3** In the event that the site uses positive release based on product pathogen or chemical testing, a procedure shall be in place to ensure that product is not released until acceptable results have been received. In the event that off-site or contract warehouses are used, these requirements shall be effectively communicated and verified as being followed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.4.8 Environmental Monitoring

Document #QMS-PLC0035 detailed the requirements of the Environmental Monitoring & Control Policy. A four (4) zone sampling methods was used and sampling sites were selected from site maps to assure that all areas were sampled over the course of a year. No pathogen sampling was conducted for Zone 1 sampling sites. Sampling was conducted weekly, with ten (10) sampling sites tested for the presence of Salmonella and four (4) sampling sites tested for the presence of Listeria. Areas that tested positive were addressed with a vigorous cleaning regimen and immediately re sampled before and after cleaning. Specific corrective actions were detailed for a positive test result in a Zone 2, Primary Pathogen Control Area, Zone 2, Basic GMP Area, Zone 3, and Zone 4 area. For a Zone 2, Primary Pathogen Control Area (Production Packaging Room - post lethality step) production was halted and a full cleaning cycle initiated, followed by re-sampling immediately before and after cleaning using a vector sampling method of the positive site and adjacent area, and sampling continued daily until three (3) consecutive negative results were recorded. For all other areas, re-sampling was conducted immediately before and after cleaning using a vector sampling method of the positive site and adjacent area and re-sampling was continued daily until three (3) consecutive negative results were recorded. The policy included the monitoring requirements for adverse events and for investigative sampling. The environmental testing results were reviewed for 2021 and 2022 YTD for the Main facility and Peanut Butter Facility. For 2021, the Main Facility had a total of 530 sampling sites tested for Salmonella, with zero (0) positive test results records and 273 sampling sites tested for Listeria, with one (1) positive test result recorded for a Zone 4 sampling site in the Shipping area and for 2022 YTD, a total of 127 sampling site were tested for Salmonella and 67 sampling site were tested for Listeria with zero (0) positive test results recorded. For 2021, Peanut Butter Facility had a total of 472 sampling sites tested for Salmonella, with zero (0) positive results recorded and 212 sampling sites tested for Listeria, with one (1) positive test result recorded a Zone 4, raw room fork truck wheels and for 2022 YTD, a total of 132 sampling site were tested for Salmonella and 58 sampling site were tested for Listeria with zero (0) positive test results recorded. The appropriate corrective actions were implemented to address the two (2) positive test results recorded for Listeria.

- 2.4.8.1** A risk-based environmental monitoring program shall be in place for all food manufacturing processes and immediate surrounding areas, which impact manufacturing processes. The responsibility and methods for the environmental monitoring program shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.8.2** An environmental sampling and testing schedule shall be prepared. It shall at a minimum: i. Detail the applicable pathogens or indicator organisms to test for in that industry; ii. List the number of samples to be taken and the frequency of sampling; iii. Outline the locations in which samples are to be taken and the rotation of locations as needed; and iv. Describe the methods to handle elevated or undesirable results.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.4.8.3** Environmental testing results shall be monitored, tracked, and trended, and preventative actions (refer to 2.5.3.1) shall be implemented where unsatisfactory results or trends are observed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.5.1 Validation and Effectiveness (Mandatory)

The methods, responsibility, and criteria for ensuring the effectiveness of all applicable elements of the SQF Program were documented and implemented. Document #QMS-PRC0180 detailed the requirements for Roaster Validation to ensure the roaster preventive controls were achieving a minimum 5 log pathogen reduction. A validation of each roaster was conducted at least annually. The validation report was reviewed for the Peanut Butter - Roaster #1 validation, conducted on 01/13/2022.

- 2.5.1.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for ensuring the effectiveness of all applicable elements of the SQF Program shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall validate that: i. Good Manufacturing Practices are confirmed to ensure they achieve the required results; ii. Critical food safety limits are reviewed annually and re-validated or justified by regulatory standards when changes occur; and iii. Changes to the processes or procedures are assessed to ensure the controls are still effective. Records of all validation activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.5.2 Verification Activities (Mandatory)

A verification schedule was documented. The schedule identified the program or activity, frequency, procedure(s), responsibility, documentation, verification, validation, validation date, and signature of the responsible person. Based on the verification schedule reviewed, all verification and validation activities identified on the schedule had been completed within the past twelve (12) months.

- 2.5.2.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for verifying monitoring of Good Manufacturing Practices, critical control points, and other food safety controls, and the legality of certified products shall be documented and implemented. The methods applied shall ensure that personnel with responsibility for verifying monitoring activities authorize each verified record.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.5.2.2** A verification schedule outlining the verification activities, their frequency of completion, and the person responsible for each activity shall be prepared and implemented. Records of verification of activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.5.3 Corrective and Preventative Action (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0048 detailed the requirements of the Corrective and Preventative Action Policy. A current Master Corrective Action Register was utilized to record the investigation, root cause analysis, and resolution of non-conformities, their corrections, and the implementation of preventative actions.

- 2.5.3.1** The responsibility and methods outlining how corrective and preventative actions are determined, implemented, and verified, including the identification of the root cause and resolution of non-compliance of critical food safety limits and deviations from food safety requirements, shall be documented and implemented. Deviations from food safety requirements may include customer complaints, nonconformances raised at internal or external audits and inspections, non-conforming product and equipment, withdrawals and recalls, as appropriate.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.5.3.2** Records of all investigation, root cause analysis, and resolution of non-conformities, their corrections, and the implementation of preventative actions shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.5.4 Internal Audits and Inspections (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PRC0003 detailed the requirements of the Internal Audit Procedure. The internal audit reports were reviewed for the following; GMP Program, completed on 02/23/2022; Allergen Program, completed on 02/21/2022; Pest Control Program, completed on 02/20/2022, and Water & Air Quality, completed on 02/02/2022. Based on the internal audit forms reviewed, objective evidence was recorded to verify compliance and/or non-compliance, corrective and preventative actions of deficiencies identified during the internal audit were undertaken, and the audit results were communicated to relevant personnel responsible for implementing and verifying the corrective and preventative actions. Personnel conducting internal audits were appropriately trained in internal audit procedures and where practical, independent of the function being audited. Monthly inspections of the site and equipment were planned and carried out to verify GMPs and facility and equipment maintenance were compliant to the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing. The GMP audit reports for the Main Facility were reviewed for the following; Cooler, Compressor, Break Rooms, Maintenance areas, and Old Honey Room, completed on 06/18/2021, Tree Nut Room, Old Warehouse, Hot Room, Offices, and Electrical room, completed on 06/23/2021, Neo Pure rooms, completed on 06/24/2021, Almond filling, Roaster rooms, New warehouse, and Shipping areas, completed on 06/29/2021, Exterior, completed on 06/30/2021, Honey, Tree Nut and Seed Wet rooms, completed on 06/30/2021, and Seed, Bulk and Bulk Roaster rooms, completed on 06/30/2021, Seed and Wet rooms, completed on 12/20/2021, Tree Nut room, Old Warehouse, Maintenance, New Warehouse and Cooler, completed on 12/28/2021, Almond Roaster room and Almond room, completed on 12/29/2021, Bulk Filling, Bulk Roaster room, and Neo Pure rooms, completed on 12/20/2021, and tree Nut Wet Honey Wet, Old Honey rooms and office areas, completed on 12/30/2021. The GMP audit reports for the Peanut Facility were reviewed for the following; Hot room and Sanitation room, completed on 09/03/2021, Break area, locker rooms, offices, and Maintenance, completed on 09/23/2021, Raw area and Roaster rooms, completed on 09/23/2021, Jar room and Bulk room, completed on 09/27/2021, Warehouse, Dock, Utility room, Compressor and Vacuum Pump areas, completed on 09/27/2021, Processing room, completed on 09/28/2021, and Waste handling and disposal area, completed on 09/28/2021.

- 2.5.4.1** The methods and responsibility for scheduling and conducting internal audits to verify the effectiveness of the SQF System shall be documented and implemented. Internal audits shall be conducted in full and at least annually. The methods applied shall ensure: i. All applicable requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing are audited per the SQF audit checklist or a similar tool; ii. Objective evidence is recorded to verify compliance and/or non-compliance; iii. Corrective and preventative actions of deficiencies identified during the internal audits are undertaken; and iv. Audit results are communicated to relevant management personnel and staff responsible for implementing and verifying corrective and preventative actions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.5.4.2** Staff conducting internal audits shall be trained and competent in internal audit procedures. Where practical, staff conducting internal audits shall be independent of the function being audited.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.5.4.3** Regular inspections of the site and equipment shall be planned and carried out to verify Good Manufacturing Practices and facility and equipment maintenance are compliant to the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing. The site shall: i. Take corrections or corrective and preventative action; and ii. Maintain records of inspections and any corrective actions taken.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.5.4.4** Records of internal audits and inspections and any corrective and preventative actions taken as a result of internal audits shall be recorded as per 2.5.3. Changes implemented from internal audits that have an impact on the site's ability to deliver safe food shall require a review of applicable aspects of the SQF System (refer to 2.3.1.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.6.1 Product Identification (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0041 detailed the requirements of the Product Identification and Trace Policy. Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, WIP, process inputs, and finished products were clearly identified during all stages of receipt, production, storage, and dispatch and finished product was labeled to the customer specification and/or regulatory requirements. Document #QMS-PRC0050 - Label Selection and document #QMS-FORM0128 - Label Control Verification Sheet were utilized to ensure that the correct product was in the correct package and with the correct label and that the changeover was inspected and approved by an authorized person.

- 2.6.1.1** The methods and responsibility for identifying raw materials, ingredients, packaging, work-in-progress, process inputs, and finished products during all stages of production and storage shall be documented and implemented to ensure: i. Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, work-in-progress, process inputs, and finished products are clearly identified during all stages of receipt, production, storage, and dispatch; and ii. Finished product is labeled to the customer specification and/or regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.6.1.2** Product start-up, product changeover, and packaging changeover (including label changes) procedures shall be documented and implemented to ensure that the correct product is in the correct package and with the correct label and that the changeover is inspected and approved by an authorized person. Procedures shall be implemented to ensure that label use is reconciled and any inconsistencies investigated and resolved. Product changeover and label reconciliation records shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.6.2 Product Trace (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0041 detailed the requirements of the Product Identification and Trace Policy. A mock recall/trace drill was conducted on a quarterly frequency to verify the effectiveness of the product trace system. The report was reviewed for the mock recall/trace drill conducted on 03/09/2022. 100% of the finished product produced was accounted for and the exercise was completed in seventy five (75) minutes. A product trace exercise was conducted during the audit. The product trace identified the raw materials, including food contact packaging used to manufacture a finished product and the loading and transport of the finished product to the first level of external distribution. The finished product identified for the product trace exercise was item code: OV3243, Organic Peanut Butter Smooth, 35 lbs. The raw materials used in the production of the finished product included; organic peanuts, lot #OR0473, supplied by Peanut Import & Distribution; plastic bucket, lot #35BP0043, supplied by Berlin; and plastic lid, lot #35LP0043, supplied by Berlin. A mass balance was completed for the raw organic peanuts. 44,000 lbs was received on 01/07/2022 and 44,000 lbs were used in production from 01/10-01/12, 2022. 342 units of item code: OV3243, Organic Peanut Butter Smooth, 35 lb pails were produced on 01/12/2022, 342 units were transferred to the off-site storage warehouse and 342 units were delivered to thirteen (13) customer locations. 100% of the raw material received and 100% of the finished product produced was accounted for and the exercise was completed in 55 minutes.

- 2.6.2.1** The responsibility and methods used to trace product shall be documented and implemented to ensure: i. Finished product is traceable at least one step forward to the customer and at least one step back from the process to the manufacturing supplier; ii. The receipt dates of raw materials, ingredients, food contact packaging and materials, and other inputs are recorded (refer to 2.8.1.8 for traceback of allergen containing food products.); iii. Traceability is maintained where product is reworked (refer to 2.4.6); and iv. The effectiveness of the product trace system is reviewed at least annually, as part of the product recall and withdrawal review (refer to 2.6.3.2). Records of raw and packaging material receipt and use and finished product dispatch and destination shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.6.3 Product Withdrawal and Recall (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PRC0020 detailed the requirements for Product Recall and Withdrawal. The roles and responsibilities of the recall team and contact information was documented in the procedure. A mock recall was conducted on a quarterly frequency. No food safety event that required public notification, including a product recall, had been initiated by the company since the previous recertification audit.

- 2.6.3.1** The responsibility and methods used to withdraw or recall product shall be documented and implemented. The procedure shall: i. Identify those responsible for initiating, managing, and investigating a product withdrawal or recall; ii. Describe the management procedures to be implemented, including sources of legal, regulatory, and expert advice, and essential traceability information; iii. Outline a communication plan to inform site personnel, customers, consumers, authorities, and other essential bodies in a timely manner appropriate about the nature of the incident; and iv. Ensure that SQFI, the certification body, and the appropriate regulatory authority are listed as essential organizations and notified in instances of a food safety incident of a public nature or product recall for any reason.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.6.3.2** The product withdrawal and recall system shall be reviewed, tested, and verified as effective at least annually. Testing shall include incoming materials (minimum traceability one step back) and finished product (minimum traceability one step forward). Testing shall be carried out on products from different shifts and for materials (including bulk materials) that are used across a range of products and/or products that are shipped to a wide range of customers.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.6.3.3** Records shall be maintained of withdrawal and recall tests, root cause investigations into actual withdrawals and recalls, and corrective and preventative actions applied.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.6.3.4** SQFI and the certification body shall be notified in writing within twenty-four (24) hours upon identification of a food safety event that requires public notification. SQFI shall be notified at foodsafetycrisis@sqfi.com.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.6.4 Crisis Management Planning

Document #QMS-PRC0027 detailed the requirements of the Crisis Management Procedure. The roles and responsibilities for the Recovery Team members were documented. The General Manager was identified as the senior manager responsible for decision making, oversight, and initiating actions arising from a crisis management incident. An active shooter was the mock scenario used to review, test and verify the effectiveness of the crisis management plan on 02/22/2022.

- 2.6.4.1** A crisis management plan based on the understanding of known potential dangers (e.g., flood, drought, fire, tsunami, or other severe weather events, warfare or civil unrest, computer outage, pandemic, loss of electricity or refrigeration, ammonia leak, labor strike) that can impact the site's ability to deliver safe food shall be documented by senior management, outlining the methods and responsibility the site shall implement to cope with such a business crisis. The crisis management plan shall include at a minimum: i. A senior manager responsible for decision making, oversight, and initiating actions arising from a crisis management incident; ii. The nomination and training of a crisis management team; iii. The controls implemented to ensure any responses do not compromise product safety; iv. The measures to isolate and identify product affected by a response to a crisis; v. The measures taken to verify the acceptability of food prior to release; vi. The preparation and maintenance of a current crisis alert contact list, including supply chain customers; vii. Sources of legal and expert advice; and viii. The responsibility for internal communications and communicating with authorities, external organizations, and media.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.6.4.2** The crisis management plan shall be reviewed, tested, and verified at least annually with gaps and appropriate corrective actions documented. Records of reviews of the crisis management plan shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.7.1 Food Defense Plan (Mandatory)

The US FDA Food Defense Plan Builder was utilized to conduct threat assessments and develop the Food Defense Plan for the Main Facility, Peanut Facility and the offsite Perry Warehouse. Instruction was provided to all relevant personnel on the effective implementation of the food defense plans. The General Manager/QA Director was identified as the person having overall responsibility for food defense. Actionable steps and mitigation strategies were documented for the ingredient feeders - oil pumps and milling in the Peanut Facility food defense plan, and the bulk room process ingredient feeders/oil pumps and milling, bulk room process - cashew Neo-Pure process, ingredient feeders/oil pumps and milling, tree room process - almond ingredient feeders/oil pumps and milling, seed room process - seed ingredient feeders/oil pumps and milling, and main boxed nuts process - nut ingredient feeders/manual additions in the Main Facility food defense plan. No actionable steps or mitigation strategies were identified in the Perry Warehouse food defense plan. An unidentified personal item left in the warehouse of the Peanut facility was the scenario used to test the effectiveness of the food defense plan on 02/10/2022

- 2.7.1.1** A food defense threat assessment shall be conducted to identify potential threats that can be caused by a deliberate act of sabotage or terrorist-like incident.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.7.1.2** A food defense plan shall be documented, implemented, and maintained based on the threat assessment (refer to 2.7.1.1). The food defense plan shall meet legislative requirements as applicable and shall include at a minimum: i. The methods, responsibility, and criteria for preventing food adulteration caused by a deliberate act of sabotage or terrorist-like incident; ii. The name of the senior site management person responsible for food defense; iii. The methods implemented to ensure only authorized personnel have access to production equipment and vehicles, manufacturing, and storage areas through designated access points; iv. The methods implemented to protect sensitive processing points from intentional adulteration; v. The measures taken to ensure the secure receipt and storage of raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, and hazardous chemicals to protect them from deliberate acts of sabotage or terrorist-like incidents; vi. The measures implemented to ensure raw materials, ingredients, packaging (including labels), work-in-progress, process inputs, and finished products are held under secure storage and transportation conditions; and vii. The methods implemented to record and control access to the premises by site personnel, contractors, and visitors.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.7.1.3** Instruction shall be provided to all relevant staff on the effective implementation of the food defense plan (refer to 2.9.2.1).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.7.1.4** The food defense threat assessment and prevention plan shall be reviewed and tested at least annually or when the threat level, as defined in the threat assessment, changes. Records of reviews and tests of the food defense plan shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.7.2 Food Fraud (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0055 detailed the requirements of the Food Fraud Policy. Instruction was provided to the relevant personnel on the effective implementation of the food fraud mitigation plan. Raw materials were rated as red - high risk, orange - medium risk, yellow - variable risk or white - low risk. Natural vanilla and maple syrup were rated as being at high-risk, almonds were identified as being at medium risk and cashews, palm oil, sunflower oil, sugar, and salt were identified as being at a variable risk to food fraud. The supplier approval program and long term relationships with ingredient suppliers were the primary mitigation strategies used to manage the risk to food fraud identified. The food fraud vulnerability assessment and mitigation plan was reviewed and verified at least annually with gaps and corrective actions documented. The review food fraud vulnerability assessment was completed on 02/22/2022.

- 2.7.2.1** The methods, responsibility, and criteria for identifying the site's vulnerability to food fraud, including susceptibility to raw material or ingredient substitution, finished product mislabeling, dilution, or counterfeiting, shall be documented, implemented, and maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.7.2.2** A food fraud mitigation plan shall be developed and implemented that specifies the methods by which the identified food fraud vulnerabilities shall be controlled, including identified food safety vulnerabilities of ingredients and materials.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.7.2.3** Instruction shall be provided to all relevant staff on the effective implementation of the food fraud mitigation plan (refer to 2.9.2.1).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.7.2.4** The food fraud vulnerability assessment and mitigation plan shall be reviewed and verified at least annually with gaps and corrective actions documented. Records of reviews shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.8.1 Allergen Management (Mandatory)

Document #QMS-PLC0006 detailed the requirements of the Allergen Control Policy. Peanut, tree nut, including almond and cashew, sesame seed, and soy were the generally recognized allergens handled at the facilities. Tree nut, including almond and cashew, sesame seed, and soy were handled at the Main Facility. Peanut was the only allergen handled at the Peanut Facility and peanut was a common allergen to all product formulations produced at the Peanut Facility. Instructions were provided to all relevant personnel involved in the receipt or handling of raw materials, WIP, rework, and finished product on how to identify, handle, store, and segregate raw materials and products containing allergens. The Main Facility had six (6) production areas including, bulk room, almond butter room, bulk nuts area, seed room, and squeeze packs. The bulk room handled tree nut, including almond and cashew, the bulk nut area handled cashew, almond and soy and sanitation was conducted between product change-over. The almond butter room handled almonds. The seed butter room handled sesame and sunflower and sanitation was conducted between product change-over. The squeeze pack packaging equipment was located seed room for packaging of sunflower butter, bulk tree nut room for the packaging of almond and cashew butter, and peanut facility for the packaging of peanut butter and spreads. ATP swabbing was used to verify and protein specific testing was used to validate the effectiveness of the allergen cleaning procedures. ATP swabbing was conducted after each tear-down cleaning event and protein specific testing was conducted at least annually. Product was labeled in compliance with the Food Allergen Labeling and Consumer Protection Act (FALCPA) for labeling of retail, foodservice, and commercial products. Cautionary labeling/allergen warning statements such as "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy sesame seed, and on equipment that processes other tree nuts" and/or "Manufactured in a facility that also processes soy, tree nuts, and on equipment that processes sesame seeds" was used for the product produced in the Main Facility. A cautionary statement "May contain occasional stem or shell fragments" was used for all products, including peanut butter and spreads.

- 2.8.1.1** The responsibility and methods used to control allergens and to prevent sources of allergens from contaminating product shall be documented and implemented. The allergen management program shall include: i. A risk analysis of those raw materials, ingredients, and processing aids, including food grade lubricants, that contain food allergens; ii. An assessment of workplace-related food allergens that may originate from locker rooms, vending machines, lunchrooms, and visitors; iii. A list of allergens that is applicable in the country of manufacture and the country(ies) of destination, if known; iv. A list of allergens that is accessible to relevant staff; v. The control of hazards associated with allergens and incorporated into the food safety plan, and vi. Management plans for control of the identified allergens.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.8.1.2** Instructions shall be provided to all relevant staff involved in the receipt or handling of raw materials, work-in-progress, rework, or finished product on how to identify, handle, store, and segregate raw materials and products containing allergens.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.8.1.3	Provisions shall be made to clearly identify and segregate foods that contain allergens. Segregation procedures shall be implemented and continually monitored. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.4	Where allergenic material may be intentionally or unintentionally present cleaning and sanitation of product contact surfaces between line changeovers shall be effective, appropriate to the risk and legal requirements, and sufficient to remove all potential target allergens from product contact surfaces, including aerosols as appropriate, to prevent cross-contact. Separate handling and production equipment shall be provided, where satisfactory line hygiene and clean-up or segregation are not possible. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.5	Based on risk assessment, procedures for validation and verification of the effectiveness of the cleaning and sanitation of areas and equipment in which allergens are used shall be documented and effectively implemented. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.6	Where allergenic material may be present, product changeover procedures shall be documented and implemented to eliminate the risk of cross-contact. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.7	The product identification system (refer to 2.6.1.1) shall make provision for clear identification and labeling, in accordance with the regulatory requirements of those products produced on production lines and equipment on which foods containing allergens are manufactured. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.8	The product trace system (refer to 2.6.2) shall take into consideration the conditions under which allergen-containing foods are manufactured and ensure full traceback of all ingredients and processing aids used. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.9	The site shall document and implement methods to control the accuracy of finished product labels (or consumer information where applicable) and assure work-in progress and finished product are true to label with regard to allergens. Measures may include label approvals at receipt, label reconciliations during production, destruction of obsolete labels, verification of labels on finished product as appropriate, and product change over procedures. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.10	Re-working of product (refer to 2.4.6) containing food allergens shall be conducted under conditions that ensure product safety and integrity are maintained. Re-worked product containing allergens shall be clearly identified and traceable. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.8.1.11	Sites that do not handle allergenic materials or produce allergenic products shall document, implement and maintain an allergen management program addressing at a minimum the mitigation of introduced or unintended allergens through supplier, contract manufacturer, site personnel, and visitor activities. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.9.1	Training Requirements Document #QMS-PRC0021 detailed the requirements for Employee Training. Appropriate training was provided for personnel carrying out the tasks essential to the effective implementation of the SQF System and the maintenance of food safety and regulatory requirements.
2.9.1.1	The responsibility for establishing and implementing the training needs of the organization's personnel to ensure they have the required competencies to carry out those functions affecting products, legality, and safety shall be defined and documented (refer to 2.1.1.6). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
2.9.1.2	Appropriate training shall be provided for personnel carrying out the tasks essential to the effective implementation of the SQF System and the maintenance of food safety and regulatory requirements. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

2.9.2 Training Program (Mandatory)

The members of the food safety team had received appropriate training in developing and maintaining food safety plans. Personnel responsible for monitoring PCs and CCPs received training in the specific monitoring procedure prior to taking on the responsibility and at least annually thereafter. QA and laboratory personnel were trained on the methods for sampling and testing of raw materials, packaging, WIP, finished products and environmental monitoring. New employees were required to complete a basic orientation program that included training in GMPs, HACCP, SQF, allergen control and food defense. Refresher training in GMPs, HACCP, allergens, illness reporting, foreign material control, GFSI/SQF, food defense, sanitation, food fraud and any other job safety or job specific training necessary for the role was provided at least annually for existing employees. An e-learning application, Alchemy, lectures, PowerPoint presentations, one point lessons (OPLs), and on-the-job training were the methods used for documenting training and procedures and the delivery of training. All training materials and procedures and the delivery of training was conducted in the English language. Records of the completion of training that complied with the requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing were maintained.

- 2.9.2.1** A training program shall be documented and implemented that at a minimum outlines the necessary competencies for specific duties and the training methods to be applied to personnel carrying out tasks associated with: i. Implementing HACCP for staff involved in developing and maintaining food safety plans; ii. Monitoring and corrective action procedures for all staff engaged in monitoring critical control points (CCPs); iii. Personal hygiene for all staff involved in the handling of food products and food contact surfaces; iv. Good Manufacturing Practices and work instructions for all staff engaged in food handling, food processing, and equipment; v. Sampling and test methods for all staff involved in sampling and testing of raw materials, packaging, work-in-progress, and finished products; vi. Environmental monitoring for relevant staff; vii. Allergen management, food defense, and food fraud for all relevant staff; and viii. Tasks identified as critical to meeting the effective implementation and maintenance of the SQF code. The training program shall include provisions for identifying and implementing the refresher training needs of the organization.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.9.2.2** Training materials, the delivery of training, and procedures on all tasks critical to meeting regulatory compliance and the maintenance of food safety shall be provided in language(s) understood by staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 2.9.2.3** Training records shall be maintained and include: i. Participant name; ii. Skills description; iii. Description of the training provided; iv. Date training completed; v. Trainer or training provider; and vi. Verification that the trainee is competent to complete the required tasks.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.1 Premises Location and Approval

The location of the premises was such that adjacent and adjoining buildings, operations and land uses did not interfere with safe and hygienic operations. The Main Facility and Peanut Plant operated as a US FDA Registered Food Facility #XXXXXXX9702 (renewal date: 12/31/2022).

- 11.1.1.1** The site shall assess local activities and the site environment to identify any risks that may have an adverse impact on product safety and implement controls for any identified risks. The assessment shall be reviewed in response to any changes in the local environment or activities. The construction and ongoing operation of the premises on the site shall be approved by the relevant authority.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.2 Building Materials

The floors in the food processing and handling areas were constructed of sealed concrete covered with an applied epoxy coating. The floors were sloped to floor drains at gradients suitable to allow the effective removal of the overflow liquid and/or wastewater under the working conditions observed during the audit. Floor drains were constructed and located so they can be easily cleaned and did not present a food safety hazard. The production facilities were not equipped with waste trap systems. Walls, partitions, ceilings, and doors were of durable construction and internal surfaces had an even and regular and light colored finished, were impervious to liquids, and appropriately maintained and kept clean. Wall-to-wall and wall-to-floor junctions were designed to be easily cleaned and sealed to prevent the accumulation of food debris. Doors and hatches were of solid construction and windows were made of shatterproof glass or a similar material. Food processing, handling and storage area were fitted with a ceiling that was constructed and maintained to prevent the contamination of products. Drop ceilings were not used in the food processing and handling areas of the production facilities. Ducting, conduit, and pipes that convey ingredients, products or services and pipes carrying sanitary waste or wastewater that were located directly over product lines or storage areas were designed, constructed, and maintained to prevent the contamination of food, ingredients, and food contact surfaces, and to allow ease of cleaning. Stairs, catwalks, and platforms in food processing and handling areas were designed, constructed, and maintained so they did not present a product-contamination risk.

11.1.2.1	Floors shall be constructed of smooth, dense, impact-resistant material that can be effectively graded, drained, impervious to liquid, and easily cleaned. Floors shall be sloped to floor drains at gradients suitable to allow the effective removal of all overflow or wastewater under normal working conditions. Where floor drainage is not available, plumbed options to handle overflow or wastewater shall be in place. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.2	Drains shall be constructed and located so they can be easily cleaned and not present a hazard. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.3	Waste trap system shall be located away from any food handling areas or entrances to the premises. RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE EVIDENCE: The production facilities were not equipped with waste trap systems.
11.1.2.4	Walls, partitions, ceilings, and doors shall be of durable construction. Internal surfaces shall have an even and regular surface and be impervious with a light-colored finish and shall be kept clean (refer to 11.2.5). Wall-to-wall and wall-to-floor junctions shall be designed to be easily cleaned and sealed to prevent the accumulation of food debris. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.5	Ducting, conduit, and pipes that convey ingredients, products, or services, such as steam or water, shall be designed and constructed to prevent the contamination of food, ingredients, and food contact surfaces and allow ease of cleaning. A risk analysis shall be conducted to ensure food contamination risks are mitigated. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.6	Pipes carrying sanitary waste or wastewater that are located directly over product lines or storage areas shall be designed and constructed to prevent the contamination of food, materials, ingredients, and food contact surfaces and shall allow ease of cleaning. A risk analysis shall be conducted to ensure food contamination risks are mitigated. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.7	Doors, hatches, and windows and their frames in food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be of a material and construction that meets the same functional requirements as for internal walls and partitions. Doors and hatches shall be of solid construction, and windows shall be made of shatterproof glass or similar material. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.8	Product shall be processed and handled in areas that are fitted with a ceiling or other acceptable structure that is constructed and maintained to prevent the contamination of products. Drop ceilings, where present, shall be constructed to enable monitoring for pest activity, facilitate cleaning, and provide access to utilities. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.2.9	Stairs, catwalks, and platforms in food processing and handling areas shall be designed and constructed so they do not present a product-contamination risk and with no open grates directly above exposed food product surfaces. They shall be kept clean (refer to 11.2.5). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.3	Lightings and Light Fittings Lighting of appropriate intensity to enable personnel to carry out their tasks efficiently and effectively were provided in the food processing and handling areas and at product inspection stations. Light fixtures in processing areas, inspection stations, ingredient and packaging storage areas, and all areas where the product was exposed were shatterproof, manufactured with a shatterproof covering or fitted with protective covers. Light fixtures in the warehouse or other areas where product was covered or otherwise protected were designed to prevent accidental breakage.
11.1.3.1	Lighting in food processing and handling areas and at inspection stations shall be of appropriate intensity to enable the staff to carry out their tasks efficiently and effectively and shall comply with local light-intensity regulations or industry standards. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.3.2 Light fixtures in processing areas, inspection stations, ingredient and packaging storage areas, and all areas where the product is exposed shall be shatterproof, manufactured with a shatterproof covering or fitted with protective covers, and recessed into or fitted flush with the ceiling. Where fixtures cannot be recessed, structures must be protected from accidental breakage, manufactured from cleanable materials, and addressed in the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.3.3 Light fixtures in the warehouse or other areas where product is covered or otherwise protected shall be designed to prevent breakage and product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.4 Inspection/ Quality Control Area

Suitable areas close to the processing line were provided for the inspection of product and provided with facilities that were suitable for examination and testing of the type of product being handled/processed.

11.1.4.1 If online inspection is required, a suitable area close to the processing line shall be provided for the inspection of product (refer to 2.4.4). The inspection/quality control area shall be provided with facilities that are suitable for examination and testing of the type of product being handled/processed. The inspection area shall: i. Have easy access to handwashing facilities; ii. Have appropriate waste handling and removal; and iii. Be kept clean to prevent product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.5 Dust, Insect, and Pest Proofing

The external windows, ventilation openings, doors, and other openings inspected were effectively sealed when closed and proofed against dust, vermin, and other pests. External personnel access doors were effectively insect-proofed and fitted with a self-closing device and proper seals to protect against entry of dust, vermin, and other pests. The pest exclusion systems used for the external overhead dock doors were observed to maintain and effective seal with the transport vehicle while the doors were in use. Pest control devices were located and operated so they did not present a contamination risk to the product, packaging, containers, or processing equipment. Poisonous rodenticide bait was not be used inside ingredients or product storage areas or processing areas where ingredients, packaging, and products were handled, processed, or exposed; the use of the rodenticide baits was restricted to the externally located bait stations.

11.1.5.1 All external windows, ventilation openings, doors, and other openings shall be effectively sealed when closed, and proofed against dust, vermin, and other pests. External personnel access doors shall be effectively insect-proofed and fitted with a self-closing device and proper seals to protect against entry of dust, vermin, and other pests.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.5.2 External doors, including overhead dock doors in food handling areas used for product, pedestrian, or truck access, shall be designed and maintained to prevent pest ingress by at least one or a combination of the following methods: i. A self-closing device; ii. An effective air curtain; iii. A pest-proof screen; iv. A pest-proof annex; and v. Adequate sealing around trucks in docking areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.5.3 Electric insect control devices, pheromone, or other traps and baits shall be located and operated so they do not present a contamination risk to the product, packaging, containers, or processing equipment. Poison rodenticide bait shall not be used inside ingredients or product storage areas or processing areas where ingredients, packaging, and products are handled, processed, or exposed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.6 Ventilation

Adequate ventilation was provided in enclosed processing and food handling areas. Positive air-pressure systems were utilized to prevent airborne contamination in the high-risk packing production areas of the Main and Peanut facilities. The ventilation equipment and devices inspected in the product storage and handling areas were adequately cleaned to prevent unsanitary conditions. Extractor fans were provided in nut and seed roasting areas. The extractor fans had sufficient capture velocities to prevent condensation build-up and to evacuate all heat, fumes, and other aerosols to the exterior of the facility. Fans and exhaust vents were insect-proofed and located so they did not pose a contamination risk.

11.1.6.1 Adequate ventilation shall be provided in enclosed processing and food handling areas. Where appropriate, positive air-pressure systems shall be installed to prevent airborne contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.6.2	All ventilation equipment and devices in product storage and handling areas shall be adequately cleaned as per 11.2.5 to prevent unsanitary conditions. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.6.3	Extractor fans and canopies shall be provided in areas where open cooking operations are carried out or a large amount of steam is generated. Capture velocities shall be sufficient to prevent condensation build-up and to evacuate all heat, fumes, and other aerosols to the exterior via an exhaust hood positioned over the cooker(s). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.6.4	Fans and exhaust vents shall be insect-proofed and located so they do not pose a contamination risk and shall be kept clean. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7	Equipment and Utensils Specifications for equipment and utensils and procedures for purchasing equipment were documented and implemented. The equipment and utensils inspected were designed, constructed, installed, operated, and maintained so as they posed no contamination threat to products. The food contact and non food contact surfaces inspected in the food handling areas, raw material storage, packaging storage, and cold storage areas were constructed of materials that did not contribute to a food safety risk. The mechanical processing equipment inspected was hygienically designed and located for appropriate cleaning. The equipment surfaces inspected were smooth, impervious to liquids, and free from cracks or crevices. Product containers used for edible and inedible material were constructed of materials that were non-toxic, smooth, impervious to liquids, and readily cleaned. The skins aspirated during the peanut blanching process step were collected and stored in supersacs. The skins were used as a source of animal feed. Equipment and utensils were cleaned after use or at a set and validated frequency to control contamination and were stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination. Equipment storage rooms were designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient storage of equipment and containers. Hot rooms were provided in the Main and Peanut facilities to dry the cleaned equipment and containers prior to being returned to the production rooms. Battery powered vehicles used in food contact, handling, or processing zones or cold storage rooms were designed, constructed, maintained and operated so as not to present a food safety hazard. Document #QMS-PRC0215 detailed the requirements of the Non Conforming Equipment Procedure. Non conforming equipment was identified with a form and a work order submitted to correct the issue.
11.1.7.1	Specifications for equipment and utensils and procedures for purchasing equipment shall be documented and implemented. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.2	Equipment and utensils shall be designed, constructed, installed, operated, and maintained to meet any applicable regulatory requirements and to not pose a contamination threat to products. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.3	Equipment storage rooms shall be designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient storage of equipment and containers. Where possible, food contact equipment shall be segregated from non-food contact equipment. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.4	Product contact surfaces and those surfaces not in direct contact with food in food handling areas, raw material storage, packaging storage, and cold storage areas shall be constructed of materials that will not contribute to a food safety risk. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.5	Benches, tables, conveyors, mixers, mincers, graders, and other mechanical processing equipment shall be hygienically designed and located for appropriate cleaning. Equipment surfaces shall be smooth, impervious, and free from cracks or crevices. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.6	Product containers, tubs, and bins used for edible and inedible material shall be constructed of materials that are non-toxic, smooth, impervious, and readily cleaned as per 11.2.5.1. Bins used for inedible material shall be clearly identified. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.7	All equipment and utensils shall be cleaned after use (refer to 11.2.5.1) or at a set and validated frequency to control contamination and be stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.1.7.8	Vehicles used in food contact, handling, or processing zones or cold storage rooms shall be designed and operated so as not to present a food safety hazard. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.7.9	Non-conforming equipment shall be identified, tagged, and/or segregated for repair or disposal in a manner that minimizes the risk of inadvertent use, improper use, or risk to the integrity of finished product. Records of the handling, corrective action, and/or disposal of non-conforming equipment shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.8	Grounds and Roadways An exterior inspection of the grounds and buildings was included in the scope of the monthly facility inspection program, as detailed in the response to 2.5.4. The grounds and area surrounding the premises were maintained to minimize dust and kept free of waste, accumulated debris or standing water so as not to attract pests and vermin. Paths, roadways, and loading and unloading areas were maintained so as not to present a hazard to the food safety operation of the premises. Roadways were covered with asphalt or concrete. Paths, roadways, loading and unloading areas were adequately drained to prevent pooling of water. Storm drains were separate from the site drainage system. Concrete paths from amenities leading to site entrances were used.
11.1.8.1	A suitable external environment shall be established, and the effectiveness of the measures shall be monitored and periodically reviewed. The premises, its surrounding areas, storage facilities, machinery, and equipment shall be kept free of waste or accumulated debris, and vegetation shall be controlled so as not to attract pests and vermin or present a food safety hazard to the sanitary operation of the site. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.8.2	Paths, roadways, and loading and unloading areas shall be maintained so as not to present a hazard to the food safety operations of the premises. They shall be adequately drained to prevent the pooling of water. Drains shall be separate from the site drainage system and regularly cleared of debris. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.1.8.3	Paths from amenities leading to site entrances shall be effectively sealed. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.1	Repairs and Maintenance Document #QMS-PRC0053 detailed the requirements of the Maintenance Work Order and Preventative Maintenance Program. A computer program, Asset Essentials CMMS, was utilized to manage the requirements of the planned and preventative maintenance requirements for both production facilities and the off-site warehouse. Failures of the plant or equipment in any food processing, handling, or storage areas were documented, reviewed, and the repair incorporated into the maintenance control schedule. Maintenance personnel reported directly to the Plant Managers. When possible, maintenance was scheduled to be conducted outside operating times. No temporary repairs that posed a food safety risk were observed during the duration of the audit. Food contact equipment and equipment located over food contact equipment was lubricated with food-grade lubricants, and the use of the lubricants controlled to minimize the contamination of the product. Paint was not used on any food contact surface inspected. Painted surfaces in the production areas were maintained in a good condition, i.e. no flaking or peeling paint.
11.2.1.1	The methods and responsibility for the maintenance and repair of plant, equipment, and buildings shall be documented, planned, and implemented in a manner that minimizes the risk of product, packaging, or equipment contamination. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.1.2	Routine maintenance of plant and equipment in any food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be performed according to a maintenance control schedule and recorded. The maintenance schedule shall be prepared to include buildings, equipment, and other areas of the premises critical to the maintenance of product safety. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.1.3	Failures of plant and equipment in any food processing, handling, or storage areas shall be documented and reviewed, and their repair(s) incorporated into the maintenance control schedule. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.1.4	Site supervisors shall be notified when maintenance or repairs are to be undertaken in any processing, handling, or storage areas. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.1.5** The maintenance supervisor and the site supervisor shall be informed if any repairs or maintenance activities pose a potential threat to product safety (e.g., pieces of electrical wire, damaged light fittings, and loose overhead fittings). When possible, maintenance is to be conducted outside operating times.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.1.6** Temporary repairs, where required, shall not pose a food safety risk and shall be included in routine inspections (refer to 2.5.4.3) and the cleaning program. There shall be a plan in place to address the completion of temporary repairs to ensure they do not become permanent solutions.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.1.7** Food contact equipment and equipment located over food contact equipment shall be lubricated with food-grade lubricant, and its use shall be controlled to minimize the contamination of the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.1.8** Paint used in a food handling or processing area shall be suitable for use, in good condition, and not be used on any product contact surfaces.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.2 Maintenance Staff and Contractors

Maintenance personnel and contractors were required to comply with the site's personnel and process hygiene requirements. Maintenance and other engineering contractors required to work on-site were trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures or were escorted at all times until their work was completed. The line clearance requirement detailed on the work orders included; tools cleaned before entering the work area; area cleaned after work was completed; inspect area and all tools and parts accounted for; production notified when work was completed; production notified if equipment needed cleaning; and tool cleaned before exiting the work area.

- 11.2.2.1** Maintenance staff and contractors shall comply with the site's personnel and process hygiene requirements (refer to 11.3).

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.2.2** All maintenance and other engineering contractors required to work on-site shall be trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures or shall be escorted at all times until their work is completed.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.2.3** Maintenance staff and contractors shall remove all tools and debris from any maintenance activity once it has been completed, and inform the area supervisor and maintenance supervisor, so appropriate hygiene and sanitation can be conducted and a pre-operational inspection completed prior to the restarting of site operations.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.3 Calibration

Document #QMS-PLC0028 detailed the requirements of the Equipment Calibration Policy. The Equipment Calibration Schedule functioned as the directory of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment that require calibration and included, processing and laboratory scales, metal detectors, glass cleaners, magnets, in-line butter screens, aflatoxin readers (Raptors), cooler temperature and humidity monitors, roaster RTDs, mill thermometers, mill feeders, peanut belt roaster, proctor belt roaster, Hunter colorimeters, moisture analyzers, hot room thermometers, lab refrigerators, and CEM Oracle (fat testing). The directory identified the equipment by name, the check frequency, calibration frequency, responsibility, and record location. The calibration accuracy of the scales, metal detectors, magnets, cooler temperature and humidity controllers, colorimeters, hot room and lab refrigerator thermometers was checked daily, the calibration accuracy of the peanut belt roaster and Proctor belt roaster was verified monthly, and the calibration accuracy of the roaster RTDs, mill thermometers, mill feed were verified twice per year. All other equipment was calibrated at least annually. Records of the calibration activities were maintained in the electronic QA files. Equipment was calibrated against national or international reference standards and methods or to an accuracy appropriate to its use. Calibration was performed according to the equipment manufacturers' recommended schedule or based on plant experience. The calibrated measuring, testing, and inspection equipment inspected was adequately protected from damage and unauthorized adjustment or use. The non conforming product and non conforming equipment hold procedures were utilized to address the resolution of potentially affected products when measuring, testing, or inspection equipment was found to be out of calibration.

11.2.3.1	The methods and responsibility for calibration and re-calibration of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment used for monitoring activities outlined in prerequisite programs, food safety plans, and other process controls, or to demonstrate compliance with customer specifications, shall be documented and implemented. Software used for such activities shall be validated as appropriate. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.3.2	Equipment shall be calibrated against national or international reference standards and methods or to an accuracy appropriate to its use. In cases where standards are not available, the site shall provide evidence to support the calibration reference method applied. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.3.3	Calibration shall be performed according to regulatory requirements and/or to the equipment manufacturers' recommended schedule. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.3.4	Procedures shall be documented and implemented to address the resolution of potentially affected products when measuring, testing, or inspection equipment is found to be out of calibration. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.3.5	Calibrated measuring, testing, and inspection equipment shall be protected from damage and unauthorized adjustment or use. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.3.6	A directory of measuring, testing, and inspection equipment that require calibration and records of the calibration tests shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.2.4	Pest Prevention Document #QMS-PLC0065 detailed the requirements of the Pest Prevention and Control Policy. Orkin was the contract service provider responsible for the development, implementation and ongoing monitoring requirements of the integrated pest management (IPM) program at both production facilities and the off-site warehouse. The scope of the IPM program included, interior and exterior rodent management, flying insect light trap (ILT) service, and insect pheromone traps for the monitoring of storage pests. The production facilities and warehouse were serviced weekly by the contract pest control service provider. The interior multi-catch rodent traps, ILTs, and pheromone traps were serviced weekly, and the exterior rodent bait stations were serviced monthly. Current schematics that detailed the number and placement of the pest control devices were documented. The Peanut Facility schematics were reviewed/verified on 03/22/2022, the Main Facility schematics were reviewed/verified on 02/03/2022, and the off-site warehouse schematics were reviewed/verified on 08/22/2021. The service reports for the Main & Peanut facilities and off-site warehouse were reviewed for the following dates: 06/01/06/07, 06/14 06/21, 06/28, 09/07, 09/13, 09/20, 09/27 12/06, 12/13, 12/20 & 12/27, 2021 and 03/07, 03/14, 03/21 & 03/28, 2022. An Approved Product List was documented and made available for review and an SDS for each approved pest control chemical was retained on site. A current pesticide usage log was maintained and the product application details were denoted on the service reports reviewed. Employees who observed pest activity or evidence of pest activity were instructed to notify the QA department who filled out the pest sighting log and/or called the pest control service provider for additional treatment. No pest activity or evidence of pest infestation was observed during the audit. No food products, raw materials, or packaging had been found to be contaminated by pest activity since the previous recertification audit. An at least annual PPGM IPM Facility Assessment, conducted on 03/15/2022 and a quarterly trend analysis were used to measure the effective of the IPM program. The device trend reports were reviewed for was reviewed for 01/13-04/13, 2022. A current State of New York Pesticide Application Business License #06791 , Commercial Pesticide Applicator certificates for the primary and back-up personnel that visited the site and a Certificate of Liability Insurance were documented and made available for review. Pest control chemical were not stored on-site. Pest control chemicals when required to be used were supplied, applied, and removed from the premises by the appropriately licensed pest control technicians employed by the pest control contract service provider. No animals were permitted on-site.
11.2.4.1	A documented pest prevention program shall be effectively implemented. It shall: i. Describe the methods and responsibility for the development, implementation, and maintenance of the pest prevention program; ii. Record pest sightings and trend the frequency of pest activity to target pesticide applications; iii. Outline the methods used to prevent pest problems; iv. Outline the pest elimination methods and the appropriate documentation for each inspection; v. Outline the frequency with which pest status is to be checked; vi. Include the identification, location, number, and type of applied pest control/monitoring devices on a site map; vii. List the chemicals used. The chemicals are required to be approved by the relevant authority and their Safety Data Sheets (SDS) made available; viii. Outline the methods used to make staff aware of the bait control program and the measures to take when they come into contact with a bait station; ix. Outline the requirements for staff awareness and training in the use of pest and vermin control chemicals and baits; and x. Measure the effectiveness of the program to verify the elimination of applicable pests and to identify trends. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.4.2 Pest contractors and/or internal pest controllers shall: i. Be licensed and approved by the local relevant authority; ii. Use only trained and qualified operators, who comply with regulatory requirements; iii. Use only approved chemicals; iv. Provide a pest prevention plan (refer to 2.3.2.8), which includes a site map, indicating the location of bait stations traps and other applicable pest control/monitoring devices; v. Report to a responsible authorized person on entering the premises and after the completion of inspections or treatments; vi. Provide regular inspections for pest activity with appropriate action taken if pests are present, and vii. Provide a written report of their findings and the inspections and treatments applied.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.4.3 Pest activity risks shall be analyzed and recorded. Inspections for pest activity shall be conducted on a regular basis by trained site personnel and the appropriate action taken if pests are present. Identified pest activity shall not present a risk of contamination to food products, raw materials, or packaging. Records of all pest control inspections and applications shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.4.4 Food products, raw materials, or packaging that are found to be contaminated by pest activity shall be effectively disposed of, and the source of pest infestation shall be investigated and resolved. Records shall be kept of the disposal, investigation, and resolution.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.4.5 Pesticides shall be clearly labeled and stored per 11.6.4 if kept on-site.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: Pest control chemical were not stored on-site.

11.2.4.6 No animals shall be permitted on-site in food handling and storage areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.5 Cleaning and Sanitation

Document #QMS-PLC0012 detailed the requirements of the Equipment Operation Condition & Sanitation Policy. Sanitation Standard Operating Procedures (SSOPs) were documented and a Master Sanitation Schedule (MSS) was developed and maintained for each area. Document #QMS-SPRC0001 was reviewed for the COP tank use. The peanut roaster was wet cleaned after 400,000 pounds of peanuts were processed. All other areas of the facility were dry wiped as required and wet cleaned prior to a product change-over or at pre-determined intervals. The MSS records were reviewed for the Peanut facility for the month of Mar, 2022. A current list and inventory of chemicals approved for use was documented and maintained. An SDS in printed copy and an electronic database were made available to the relevant personnel. Detergents and sanitizers that were required to be mixed for use were correctly mixed according to the manufacturers' instructions, stored in containers that were suitable for use, and clearly identified. Mix concentrations were verified for each COP tank use, daily for Oxywave and ProClean, and weekly for all other detergents and sanitizers. The titration log sheet was reviewed for the week of 02/20-02/24, 2022. The records reviewed indicated the chemicals were used at the recommended concentrations. Suitably equipped clean-out of-place (COP) areas were provided for cleaning product containers, utensils, and equipment parts. The COP areas and operations were appropriately controlled so they did not interfere with manufacturing operations, equipment, or product. Racks and containers for storing cleaned utensils were provided, when required. Hot rooms were provided for the drying of the COP cleaned containers, utensils, and equipment parts. Cleaning equipment, tools, racks, and other items used in support of the cleaning and sanitizing program were clearly identified, stored, and maintained in a manner that prevented contamination of processing areas, product handling equipment, and storage areas, as well as the tools themselves. Cleaning-in-place (CIP) systems were not used. Pre-operational inspections were conducted following cleaning and sanitation operations to ensure food processing areas, product contact surfaces, equipment, and other essential areas were clean before the start of production. Pre-operational inspections were conducted by qualified QA personnel. Company employed, dedicated sanitation personnel were responsible for the cleaning of the staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas of the facilities and off-site warehouse and were inspected by qualified personnel at a defined frequency to ensure the areas were clean. Visual inspection, ATP swabbing, and microbiological sampling of food contact surfaces were the methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning procedures. Visual inspection and ATP swabbing were conducted after each wet cleaning event. Microbiological sampling of the food contact surfaces was conducted at least annually. The absence of visible food residue on the food contact surfaces, and RLU <150, and a test results of <100 cfu for total plate count (TPC) and/or <10 cfu for coliforms were the acceptable limits for visual inspection, ATP swabbing, and microbiological sampling. 11.2.5.1 - Minor Non Conformance: Several of the monthly cleaning tasks identified for the Peanut Facility Processing Room were not completed and a reason as to why the tasks were not completed was not documented.

11.2.5.1 The methods and responsibility for the effective cleaning of the food handling and processing equipment and environment and storage areas shall be documented and implemented. Consideration shall be given to: i. What is to be cleaned; ii. How it is to be cleaned; iii. When it is to be cleaned; iv. Who is responsible for the cleaning; v. Validation of the cleaning procedures for food contact surfaces (including CIP); vi. Methods used to confirm the correct concentrations of detergents and sanitizers; and vii. The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning and sanitation program.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: Several of the monthly cleaning tasks identified for the Peanut Facility Processing Room were not completed and a reason as to why the tasks were not completed was not documented.

ROOT CAUSE: Form not designed with section or instruction for comments when a task was not completed. Procedure not developed outlining what to do if task not complete.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: 1. Update Equipment Operation Condition & Sanitation Policy - QMS-PLC0012 to including more detail on how we're going to monitor/communicate compliance rates. 2. Create a procedure on on how we're going to monitor/communicate compliance.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Effectiveness of implementation to be verified during the next recertification audit.

COMPLETION DATE: 04/29/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

11.2.5.2 Detergents and sanitizers shall be suitable for use in a food manufacturing environment, labeled according to regulatory requirements, and purchased in accordance with applicable legislation. The organization shall ensure: i. The site maintains a list of chemicals approved for use; ii. An inventory of all purchased and used chemicals is maintained; iii. Detergents and sanitizers are stored as outlined in element 11.6.4; iv. Safety Data Sheets (SDS) are provided for all detergents and sanitizers purchased; and v. Only trained staff handle sanitizers and detergents.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.5.3 Detergents and sanitizers that have been mixed for use shall be correctly mixed according to the manufacturers' instructions, stored in containers that are suitable for use, and clearly identified. Mix concentrations shall be verified and records maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.5.4 Cleaning-in-place (CIP) systems, where used, shall not pose a chemical contamination risk to raw materials, ingredients, or product. CIP parameters critical to assuring effective cleaning shall be defined, monitored, and recorded (e.g., chemical and concentration used, contact time, and temperature). CIP equipment, including spray balls, shall be maintained, and any modifications to CIP equipment shall be validated. Personnel engaged in CIP activities shall be effectively trained.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: Cleaning-in-place (CIP) systems were not used.

11.2.5.5 Cleaning equipment, tools, racks, and other items used in support of the cleaning and sanitizing program shall be clearly identified, stored, and maintained in a manner that prevents contamination of processing areas, product handling equipment, and storage areas as well as the tools themselves.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.5.6 Suitably equipped areas shall be designated for cleaning product containers, knives, cutting boards, and other utensils used by staff. The areas for these cleaning operations shall be controlled so they do not interfere with manufacturing operations, equipment, or product. Racks and containers for storing cleaned utensils shall be provided as required.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.5.7 Pre-operational inspections shall be conducted following cleaning and sanitation operations to ensure food processing areas, product contact surfaces, equipment, staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas are clean before the start of production. Pre-operational inspections shall be conducted by qualified personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.2.5.8 Staff amenities, sanitary facilities, and other essential areas shall be inspected by qualified personnel at a defined frequency to ensure the areas are clean.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.2.5.9** The responsibility and methods used to verify the effectiveness of the cleaning procedures shall be documented and implemented. A verification schedule shall be prepared. A record of pre-operational hygiene inspections, cleaning and sanitation activities, and verification activities shall be maintained.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.3.1 Personnel Welfare

Document #QMS-PRC0227 detailed the requirements for Illness Reporting. Personnel who were known to be carriers of infectious diseases that presented a health risk to others through the packing or storage processes were not permitted to engage in the processing or packing of food or to enter storage areas where food was exposed. Employees were required to report to the HR department prior to entering any work areas for the following; and onset of jaundice, diarrhea, vomiting, fever, sore throat with fever or visibly infected skin lesions, infected cuts, wounds or lesions containing pus on hand, wrist, an exposed part or other body part or who were diagnosed with being ill with, exposed to, or having a household member diagnosed with any of the following; Astroviruses; Bacillus cereus; Campylobacter jejuni; Clostridium perfringens; Cryptosporidium species; Entamoeba histolytica; Enterorhemorrhagic E. coli; Enterotoxigenic E. coli; Giardiasis; Hepatitis A virus; Nontyphoidal Salmonella; Noroviruses; Rotaviruses; Salmonella typhi; sapoviruses; Shigella species; Staphylococcus aureus; Streptococcus pyogenes; Taenia solium - cysticercosis; Vibrio cholera; and Yersinia enterocolitica. Personnel with exposed cuts, sores, or lesions were not permitted engage in handling or processing exposed products or handling food contact packaging or touching food contact surfaces. Minor cuts or abrasions on exposed parts of the body were required to be covered with a company provided, colored, metal-detectable bandage or an alternative suitable waterproof and colored dressing. Bandages used on the hands or fingers were required to be covered by a glove. Adequate measures were developed and implemented to prevent the contact of materials, ingredients, food packaging, food, or food contact surfaces from any bodily fluids, open wounds, coughing, sneezing, spitting, or any other means. Document #QMS-SAFETY0023 detailed the requirements for BloodBorne Pathogen Exposure Control.

- 11.3.1.1** Personnel who are known to be carriers of infectious diseases that present a health risk to others through the packing or storage processes shall not engage in the processing or packing of food or enter storage areas where food is exposed. Code Amendment #1 A medical screening procedure shall be in place for all employees, visitors and contractors who handle exposed product or food contact surfaces.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.3.1.2** The site shall have measures in place to prevent contact of materials, ingredients, food packaging, food, or food contact surfaces from any bodily fluids, open wounds, coughing, sneezing, spitting, or any other means. In the event of an injury that causes the spillage of bodily fluid, a properly trained staff member shall ensure that all affected areas, including handling and processing areas, have been adequately cleaned, and that all materials and products have been quarantined and/or disposed of.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.3.1.3** Personnel with exposed cuts, sores, or lesions shall not engage in handling or processing exposed products or handling primary (food contact) packaging or touching food contact surfaces. Minor cuts or abrasions on exposed parts of the body shall be covered with a colored, metal-detectable bandage or an alternative suitable waterproof and colored dressing.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.3.2 Handwashing

Handwashing stations were provided adjacent to all personnel access points and in accessible locations throughout food handling and processing areas. All handwashing stations were constructed of stainless steel, equipped hands-free operated taps and supplied warm potable water, liquid soap, single use paper towels, a trash container to contain the used paper towels, liquid hand sanitizer, and instructional hand wash signage. Personnel were observed to comply with requirements of the SQF Code for hand washing and hand washing when the use of gloves was required.

- 11.3.2.1** All personnel shall have clean hands, and hands shall be washed by all staff, contractors, and visitors: i. On entering food handling or processing areas; ii. After each visit to a toilet; iii. After using a handkerchief; iv. After smoking, eating, or drinking; and v. After handling wash down hoses, cleaning materials, dropped product, or contaminated material.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.3.2.2** Handwashing stations shall be provided adjacent to all personnel access points and in accessible locations throughout food handling and processing areas as required.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.3.2.3	Handwashing stations shall be constructed of stainless steel or similar non-corrosive material and at a minimum supplied with: i. A potable water supply at an appropriate temperature; ii. Liquid soap contained within a fixed dispenser; iii. Paper towels in a hands-free cleanable dispenser; and iv. A means of containing used paper towels. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.2.4	The following additional facilities shall be provided in high-risk areas: i. Hands-free operated taps; and ii. Hand sanitizers. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.2.5	Signage in appropriate languages instructing people to wash their hands before entering the food processing areas shall be provided in a prominent position in break rooms, at break room exits, toilet rooms, and in outside eating areas, as applicable. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.2.6	When gloves are used, personnel shall maintain the handwashing practices outlined above. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.3	Clothing and Personal Effects A risk analysis to ensure that the clothing and hair restraint policies adequately protected materials, food, and food contact surfaces from unintentional microbiological or physical contamination was documented. All personnel were required to wear a company provided uniform (shirt & pants) or a protective outer garment over appropriate street clothing when entering into the production areas of the Main and Peanut processing facilities. The uniforms and protective over garments worn by personnel engaged in handling food were maintained, stored, laundered, and worn so as not to present a contamination risk to the products. Clothing, including shoes, was required and observed to be clean at the start of each shift and maintained in a serviceable condition. Excessively soiled uniforms were changed or replaced when they presented a product contamination risk. The uniforms and protective outer garments were manufactured from material that were not likely to pose a food safety threat and were easily cleaned or intended to be used as disposable items. Racks located nearby or adjacent to the personnel access doorways and handwashing facilities were provided for the temporary storage of protective clothing when personnel left the processing area. Employees coming into direct contact with the food, food contact surfaces or food contact packaging were required to wear single use, disposable gloves. Employees were not required to wear aprons or sleeve guards. Non-disposable gloves, aprons or sleeve guard were not used by production employees. Jewelry, with the exception of plain bands with no stones, prescribed medical alert jewelry, and other loose objects were not permitted to be worn or taken into a food handling or processing operation or into any area where food is exposed.
11.3.3.1	The site shall undertake a risk analysis to ensure that the clothing and hair policy protects materials, food, and food contact surfaces from unintentional microbiological or physical contamination. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.3.2	Clothing worn by staff engaged in handling food shall be maintained, stored, laundered, and worn so it does not present a contamination risk to products. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.3.3	Clothing, including shoes, shall be clean at the start of each shift and maintained in a serviceable condition. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.3.4	Excessively soiled uniforms shall be changed or replaced when they present a product contamination risk. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.3.5	Disposable gloves and aprons shall be changed after each break, upon re-entry into the processing area, and when damaged. Non-disposable aprons and gloves shall be cleaned and sanitized as required and when not in use stored on racks provided in the processing area or in designated sealed containers in personnel lockers. They should not be placed or stored on packaging, ingredients, product, or equipment. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.3.6	Protective clothing shall be manufactured from material that will not pose a food safety threat and is easily cleaned. All protective clothing shall be cleaned after use, or at a frequency to control contamination, and stored in a clean and serviceable condition to prevent microbiological or cross-contact allergen contamination. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.3.3.7	Racks shall be provided for the temporary storage of protective clothing when staff leave the processing area and shall be provided nearby or adjacent to the personnel access doorways and handwashing facilities.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.3.8	Jewelry and other loose objects shall not be worn or taken into a food handling or processing operation or into any area where food is exposed. Wearing plain bands with no stones, prescribed medical alert bracelets, or jewelry accepted for religious or cultural reasons can be permitted, provided these items are properly covered and do not pose a food safety risk. All exceptions shall meet regulatory and customer requirements and shall be subject to a risk assessment and evidence of ongoing risk management.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.4 Visitors	
Visitors, including management, maintenance employees, and contractors were required to comply with the requirements of site GMP policy, which included the wearing of appropriate clothing, the reporting of communicable disease or illness, to enter and exit food handling areas through the appropriate entrance points, and to comply with the facility hand washing and personnel practice requirements. Visitors were required to be escorted at all times while in the in food processing, handling and storage areas.	
11.3.4.1	All visitors shall be trained in the site's food safety and hygiene procedures before entering any food processing and handling areas or shall be escorted at all times in food processing, handling, and storage areas.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.4.2	All visitors, including management staff, shall be required to remove jewelry and other loose objects in accordance with the facilities Good Manufacturing Practices and 11.3.3.8. All visitors shall wear suitable clothing and footwear when entering any food processing and handling area.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.4.3	Visitors exhibiting visible signs of illness shall be prevented from entering areas in which food is handled and processed.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.4.4	Visitors shall enter and exit food handling areas through the proper staff entrance points and comply with all handwashing and personnel practice requirements.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.5 Staff Amenities (change rooms, toilet, break rooms)	
Staff amenities complied with the requirements of the SOF code for lighting and ventilation and were made available for use by all persons engaged in the handling and processing of product. Change/lockers rooms were provided and observed to be appropriately maintained. High-risk change areas were provided for personnel engaged in the processing of high-risk foods, as detailed in the response to 11.7.4. Employees were provided with secure lockers to store their outdoor clothing and personal items. Showers were not required, but were provided for employee use in the production facility change rooms. Toilet rooms complied with the SQF Code requirements for size, number, location, construction and ventilation and were observed to be adequately maintained. Hand wash basins supplied with warm potable water, liquid soap, paper towels and hand wash signage were located inside the employee rest rooms. The sanitary drainage system was connected directly to municipal sewerage system. The lunch/break rooms were appropriately located and physically segregated from the food processing, handling and storage areas of the facility. The employee lunch/break rooms were supplied with adequate ventilation and lighting, sufficient in size for the number employees working at each facility, equipped with a sink serviced by hot and cold potable water, a refrigerator to store perishable foods and a means to heat or reheat food, and were observed to be adequately cleaned and maintained. Signage instructing people to wash their hands before entering the food processing areas was provided in a prominent position in lunch-rooms, at lunch-room exits and in outside eating areas. Outside eating areas were kept clean and free from waste materials and maintained in a manner that minimizes the potential for introduction of contamination including pest into the site.	
11.3.5.1	Staff amenities shall have documented cleaning procedures, be supplied with appropriate lighting and ventilation, and shall be made available for use by all persons engaged in the handling and processing of product.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	
11.3.5.2	Change rooms shall be provided to enable staff and visitors to change into and out of protective clothing as required. Change rooms shall be kept clean.
RESPONSE: COMPLIANT	

11.3.5.3	High-risk change areas shall be provided for staff engaged in the processing of high-risk foods or processing operations in which clothing can be soiled. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.4	Provision shall be made for staff to store their street clothing and personal items separate from clean uniforms, food contact zones, food, and packaging storage areas. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.5	Where required, a sufficient number of showers shall be provided for use by staff. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.6	Toilet rooms shall be: i. Designed and constructed so that they are accessible to staff and separate from any processing and food handling operations; ii. Accessed from the processing area via an airlock vented to the exterior or through an adjoining room; iii. Sufficient in number for the maximum number of staff; iv. Constructed so that they can be easily cleaned and maintained; v. Located inside or nearby areas for storing protective clothing, outer garments, and other items while using the facilities; and vi. Kept clean and tidy. Tools/equipment used for cleaning toilet rooms shall not be used to clean processing areas. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.7	Sanitary drainage shall not be connected to any other drains within the premises and shall be directed to a septic tank or a sewerage system in accordance with regulations. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.8	Handwashing basins shall be provided immediately outside or inside the toilet room and designed as outlined in 11.3.2.3. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.9	Separate break rooms shall be provided away from food contact/handling zones. Break rooms shall be: i. Ventilated and well lit; ii. Provided with adequate tables and seating to cater for the maximum number of staff at one sitting; iii. Equipped with a sink serviced with hot and cold potable water for washing utensils; iv. Equipped with refrigeration and heating facilities, enabling staff to store or heat food and to prepare non-alcoholic beverages if required; and v. Kept clean and free from waste materials and pests. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.3.5.10	Where outside eating areas are provided, they should be kept clean and free from waste materials and maintained in a manner that minimizes the potential for the introduction of contamination, including pests to the site. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.4.1	Staff Engaged in Food Handling and Processing Operations Personnel were observed to comply with the requirements of the SQF Food Safety Code: Food Manufacturing for staff engaged in food handling and processing operations. All personnel were required to wear a scalp hair restraint/hair net and personnel with facial hair, including a beard or moustache were required to wear a facial hair restraint/beard net when entering into any the food processing, handling or storage area. Smoking, chewing, eating, or spitting was not permitted or observed in areas where product was produced, stored, or otherwise exposed. Smoking, including the use of e-cigarettes was restricted to the externally located designated smoking areas. Drinking water coolers and the use of company issued drinking water containers was permitted in the food processing, handling or storage areas of the facility. The consumption of water was adequately controlled to prevent product contamination or other food safety risks from occurring. The flow of personnel in food processing and handling areas was managed such that the potential for contamination was minimized. Document #QMS-PRC0029 detailed the requirements for conducting sensory evaluation of the product in the food handling/contact zones. Production employees were trained in sensory testing before being able to sample product. The procedure required the product sample to be taken off-line to a designated area, sampled and tasted using a sterile tongue depressor that was supplied, the sampled product and used tongue depressor were disposed of in the trash receptacle, the employee was required wash (if soiled) and sanitize their hands prior to returning to the production line, and the data was recorded on the process control or roaster form.
11.4.1.1	All personnel engaged in any food handling, preparation, or processing operations shall ensure that products and materials are handled and stored in such a way as to prevent damage or product contamination. They shall comply with the following processing practices: i. Personnel entry to processing areas shall be through the personnel access doors only; ii. All doors are to be kept closed. Doors shall not be open for extended periods when access is required for waste removal or receiving of product/ingredient/packaging; iii. Packaging, product, and ingredients shall be kept in appropriate containers as required and off the floor; iv. Waste shall be contained in the bins identified for this purpose and removed from the processing area on a regular basis and not left to accumulate; and v. All wash down and compressed air hoses shall be stored on hose racks after use and not left on the floor. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.4.1.2	Personnel working in or visiting food handling or processing operations shall ensure that: i. Staff shall not eat or taste any product being processed in the food handling/contact zones, except as noted in element 11.4.1.4; ii. The wearing of false fingernails, false eyelashes, eyelash extensions, long nails, or fingernail polish is not permitted when handling exposed food; iii. Hair restraints and beard covers, where applicable, shall be used in areas where product is exposed. iv. Smoking, chewing, eating, or spitting is not permitted in areas where product is produced, stored, or otherwise exposed. v. Drinking water is permissible only under conditions that prevent contamination or other food safety risks from occurring. Drinking water containers in production and storage areas shall be stored in clear, covered containers, and in designated areas away from raw materials, packaging, tools, or equipment storage. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.4.1.3	The flow of personnel in food processing and handling areas shall be managed such that the potential for contamination is minimized. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.4.1.4	In circumstances where it is necessary to undertake sensory evaluations in a food handling/contact zone, the site shall implement controls and procedures to ensure: i. Food safety is not compromised; ii. Sensory evaluations are conducted by authorized personnel only; iii. A high standard of personal hygiene is practiced by personnel conducting sensory evaluations; iv. Sensory evaluations are conducted in areas equipped for the purpose; and v. Equipment used for sensory evaluations is sanitized, maintained, and stored separately from processing equipment. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.5.1	Water Supply An adequate supply of potable water was sourced from an EPA regulated municipal supplier, the Village of Nunda, NY. Potable water was not required to be stored on-site. Document #QMS-PLC0005 detailed the requirements of the Water & Air Quality Policy including the contingency plan when potable water was not available or there was damage to the supply system. All wet cleaning activities were stopped until the supply was restored, an alternative way for employees to maintain hand washing practices was implemented, and the actions of all activities taken were documented. An adequate supply of hot and cold water was provided to enable the effective cleaning of the premises and equipment. The Main Facility and the Peanut Facility were each equipped with three (3) back flow prevention devices and an inspection and test of each device was conducted at least annually. The inspection and test results were reviewed for the service provided on 08/01/2021. A source of non potable water was not used.
11.5.1.1	Adequate supplies of potable water drawn from a known clean source shall be provided for water used as an ingredient during processing operations and for cleaning the premises and equipment. The source of potable water shall be identified as well as on-site storage (if applicable) and reticulation within the facility. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.5.1.2	Contingency plans shall be in place for instances when the potable water supply is deemed to be contaminated or otherwise inappropriate for use. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.5.1.3	Supplies of hot and cold water shall be provided, as required, to enable the effective cleaning of the premises and equipment. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.5.1.4	The delivery of water within the premises shall ensure potable water is not contaminated. Testing of the backflow system, where possible, shall be conducted at least annually and records shall be maintained. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.5.1.5	The use of non-potable water shall be controlled such that: i. There is no cross-contamination between potable and non-potable water lines; ii. Non-potable water piping and outlets are clearly identified; and iii. Hoses, taps, and other similar sources of possible contamination are designed to prevent backflow or back-siphonage. RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE EVIDENCE: A source of non potable water was not used.
11.5.1.6	Where water is stored on-site, storage facilities shall be adequately designed, constructed, and routinely cleaned to prevent contamination. RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE EVIDENCE: Potable water was not required to be stored on-site

11.5.2 Water Treatment

The potable water supply was not further treated on-site.

- 11.5.2.1** Water treatment methods, equipment, and materials, if required, shall be designed, installed, and operated to ensure water receives effective treatment. Water treatment equipment shall be monitored regularly to ensure it remains serviceable.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

- 11.5.2.2** Water used as an ingredient in processing or for cleaning and sanitizing equipment shall be tested and, if required, treated to maintain potability (refer to 11.5.2.1).

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

- 11.5.2.3** Treated water shall be regularly monitored to ensure it meets the specified indicators. Water treatment chemicals usage shall be monitored to ensure chemical residues are within acceptable limits. Records of testing results shall be kept.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

11.5.3 Water Quality

Water used for handwashing and for cleaning food contact surfaces and equipment was required to comply with the relevant microbiological and quality standards. A water sample from each facility was submitted for heavy metal (copper and lead) testing at least annually. The test results were reviewed for the water samples collected on 01/10/2022. Microbiological analysis of the water supply, sampled from multiple locations within both production facilities, was conducted at least annually. The test results were reviewed for water samples collected on 01/10/2022. All test results reviewed were reported as negative for total coliforms and E. coli. The reference standards and methods used for the analyses were denoted on the Laboratory Analysis Report issued by the external laboratory; the microbiological analysis was conducted using a Colilert method.

- 11.5.3.1** Water shall comply with local, national, or internationally recognized potable water microbiological and quality standards, as required when used for: i. Washing, thawing, and treating food; ii. Handwashing; iii. Conveying food; iv. An ingredient or food processing aid; v. Cleaning food contact surfaces and equipment; vi. The manufacture of ice; or vii. The manufacture of steam that will come into contact with food or be used to heat water that will come into contact with food.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.5.3.2** Microbiological analysis of the water and ice supply shall be conducted to verify the cleanliness of the supply, the monitoring activities, and the effectiveness of the treatment measures implemented. Samples for analysis shall be taken at sources supplying water for the process or cleaning or from within the site. The frequency of analysis shall be risk-based and at a minimum annually.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.5.3.3** Water and ice shall be analyzed using reference standards and methods.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.5.4 Ice Supply

Purchased or self manufacture ice was not used during processing operations, as a processing aid, or an ingredient. Ice rooms or receptacles were not required to be used.

- 11.5.4.1** Ice provided for use during processing operations, as a processing aid, or an ingredient shall comply with 11.5.3.1.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

- 11.5.4.2** Ice that is purchased shall be from an approved supplier and included in the site's food safety risk assessment. Ice shall be supplied in containers that are appropriate for use, cleanable if reused, and tested as appropriate.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

- 11.5.4.3** Ice rooms and receptacles shall be constructed of materials as outlined in element 11.1.2 and designed to minimize contamination of the ice during storage, retrieval, and distribution.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

11.5.5 Air and Other Gasses

Compressed air was used to rinse the glass containers prior to filling. A coalescing filter was used to remove water, oil and particulate contaminants. An analysis of the compressed air that included oxygen, carbon monoxide, total gaseous hydrocarbons, including methane, carbon dioxide, oil mist, particulate, and water and a microbiological analysis for bacteria and yeast and mold was conducted at least annually for each glass container rinser. The chemical and microbiological test results were reviewed for the testing conducted on 01/24/2022.

- 11.5.5.1** Compressed air or other gases (e.g., nitrogen or carbon dioxide) that contact food or food contact surfaces shall be clean and present no risk to food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.5.5.2** Compressed air systems and systems used to store or dispense other gases that come into contact with food or food contact surfaces shall be maintained and regularly monitored for quality and applicable food safety hazards. The frequency of analysis shall be risk-based and at a minimum annually.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.6.1 Receipt, Storage and Handling of Goods

An effective storage plan that allows for the safe, hygienic receipt and storage of raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, and chemicals was implemented at the production facilities and off-site warehouse. Adequate controls were developed and implemented to ensure all ingredients, raw materials, processing aids, and packaging were received and stored properly to prevent cross-contamination risks. Unprocessed raw materials were received and stored separately from processed raw materials to avoid cross-contamination risk. A computerized inventory management system, SAGE100 was utilized to ensure effective stock rotation principles were followed. No expired raw materials, ingredients, packaging materials or finished products were observed in the storage or production areas during the duration of the audit. Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, chemicals, or finished products were not held under temporary or overflow conditions that were not designed for the safe storage of goods during the audit.

- 11.6.1.1** The site shall document and implement an effective storage plan that allows for the safe, hygienic receipt and storage of raw materials (i.e., frozen, chilled, and ambient), ingredients, packaging, equipment, and chemicals.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.1.2** Controls shall be in place to ensure all ingredients, raw materials, processing aids, and packaging are received and stored properly to prevent cross-contamination risks. Unprocessed raw materials shall be received and stored separately from processed raw materials to avoid cross-contamination risk.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.1.3** The responsibility and methods for ensuring effective stock rotation principles shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.1.4** Procedures shall be in place to ensure that all ingredients, materials, work- in-progress, rework, and finished product are utilized within their designated shelf-life.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.1.5** Where raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, and chemicals are held under temporary or overflow conditions that are not designed for the safe storage of goods, a risk analysis shall be undertaken to ensure there are no risks to the integrity of those goods, no potential for contamination or adverse effect on food safety.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, chemicals, or finished products were not held under temporary or overflow conditions that were not designed for the safe storage of goods during the audit.

- 11.6.1.6** Records shall be available to verify the effectiveness of alternate or temporary control measures for the storage of raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, chemicals, or finished products.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: Raw materials, ingredients, packaging, equipment, chemicals, or finished products were not held under temporary or overflow conditions that were not designed for the safe storage of goods during the audit.

11.6.2 Cold Storage, Freezing and Chilling of Foods

The Main Facility and the off-site warehouse were equipped with storage coolers, primarily used for the storage of raw materials including, seeds and almonds, salt, sugar, and finished box nut products. The refrigerated storage was done for shelf extension, not for product safety. The operating temperature range for the storage coolers was 36 - 50 deg F. The coolers were equipped with a temperature and humidity monitoring instrument. The temperature and humidity readings from the instrument's digital display were manually recorded at least daily. The temperature monitoring records for the Main Facility and Off-site warehouse were reviewed for the 01/12/2022 production dated indentified in the product trace exercise. Based on the temperature monitoring records reviewed, sufficient refrigeration capacity was available to store chilled the maximum anticipated throughput of product with allowance for periodic cleaning of refrigerated areas. Discharge from defrost and condensate lines was controlled and discharged into the drainage system.

- 11.6.2.1** The site shall provide confirmation of the effective operational performance of freezing, chilling, and cold storage facilities. Chillers, blast freezers, and cold storage rooms shall be designed and constructed to allow for the hygienic and efficient refrigeration of food and be easily accessible for inspection and cleaning.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.2.2** Sufficient refrigeration capacity shall be available to chill, freeze, store chilled, or store frozen the maximum anticipated throughput of product with allowance for periodic cleaning of refrigerated areas.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.2.3** The site shall have a written procedure for monitoring temperatures, including the frequency of checks, and corrective actions, if the temperature is out of specification. Freezing, chilling, and cold storage rooms shall be fitted with temperature monitoring equipment that is located to monitor the warmest part of the room and be fitted with a temperature measurement device that is easily readable and accessible. Records shall be kept of frozen, cold, and chilled storage room temperatures.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.2.4** Discharge from defrost and condensate lines shall be controlled and discharged into the drainage system.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.6.3 Storage of Dry Ingredients, Packaging, and Shelf Stable Packaged Goods

Rooms used for the storage of ingredients, packaging, and other dry goods were located away from wet areas and constructed to protect the materials from contamination and deterioration and prevent packaging from becoming a harborage for pests or vermin. Metal racks provided for the storage of packaging were designed and constructed to enable cleaning and inspection of the floors underneath and behind the racks. Cleaning of the storage areas was detailed in the MCS, as detailed in the response to 11.2.5.1.

- 11.6.3.1** Rooms used for the storage of product ingredients, packaging, and other dry goods shall be located away from wet areas and constructed to protect the product from contamination and deterioration and prevent packaging from becoming a harborage for pests or vermin.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.3.2** Racks provided for the storage of packaging shall be constructed of impervious materials and designed to enable cleaning and inspection of the floors and behind the racks. Storage areas shall be cleaned at a pre-determined frequency.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.6.4 Storage of Hazardous Chemicals and Toxic Substances

Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances with the potential for food contamination were clearly labeled, included in a current register, and a current SDS was made available to all relevant personnel. Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances were stored in designated areas in a manner that prevented a hazard to finished product or product contact surfaces. Processing utensils and packaging were not observed to be stored in areas used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances. Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances were used according to manufacturers' instructions, controlled to prevent contamination or a hazard to raw and packaging material, work-in-progress, finished product, or product contact surfaces, and returned to the appropriate storage areas after use. Daily supplies of chemicals were appropriately managed. Personnel who handled hazardous chemicals and toxic substances were fully trained and provided with first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment (PPE). Empty, obsolete, and unused chemicals were segregated and securely stored prior to collection and disposed of through an approved vendor. Empty chemical containers were not reused, segregated, and securely stored prior to collection, and disposed through an approved vendor. Spillage clean-up instructions and PPE, spillage kits, and cleaning equipment were provided for the containment and clean-up of chemical spills. 11.6.4.2 - Minor Non Conformance: Chemical cabinets used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances and/or the areas in which the chemical cabinets were located were not secure in order to effectively restricted access to the hazardous chemicals and toxic substances to authorized personnel only.

- 11.6.4.1** Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances with the potential for food contamination shall be: i. Clearly labeled, identifying and matching the contents of their containers; ii. Included in a current register of all hazardous chemicals and toxic substances that are stored on-site; and iii. Supplemented with current Safety Data Sheets (SDS) made available to all staff.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.4.2** Storage of hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be: i. Located in an area with appropriate signage indicating that the area is for hazardous storage; ii. Controlled, lockable, and accessible only by personnel trained in the storage and use of chemicals; iii. Adequately ventilated; iv. Stored where intended and not comingled (e.g., food versus non-food grade); v. Designed such that pesticides, rodenticides, fumigants, and insecticides are stored separately from sanitizers and detergents; and vi. Stored in a manner that prevents a hazard to finished product or product contact surfaces. Processing utensils and packaging shall not be stored in areas used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances.

RESPONSE: MINOR

EVIDENCE: Chemical cabinets used to store hazardous chemicals and toxic substances and/or the areas in which the chemical cabinets were located were not secure in order to effectively restricted access to the hazardous chemicals and toxic substances to authorized personnel only.

ROOT CAUSE: Details on secured storage for chemicals and lubricants were not included in the Chemical Control Policies - QMS-PLC0010, New Chemical & Lubricant Approval - QMS-PRC0041, or Chemical/Lubricant Approval Request - QMS-FORM0089

CORRECTIVE ACTION: 1. Update Chemical Control Policies - QMS-PLC0010 to include details on securing maintenance and production storage cabinets along with maintenance shops. 2. Place temporary locks on cabinets. 3. Install Door Security (PHAB ACCESS) System.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Effectiveness of implementation to be verified during the next recertification audit.

COMPLETION DATE: 04/21/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

- 11.6.4.3** Hazardous chemicals and toxic substances shall be correctly labeled and: i. Used only according to manufacturers' instructions; ii. Controlled to prevent contamination or a hazard to raw and packaging material, work-in-progress, finished product, or product contact surfaces; iii. Returned to the appropriate storage areas after use; and iv. Be compliant with national and local legislation.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.4.4** Daily supplies of chemicals used for continuous sanitizing of water, as a processing aid, or for emergency cleaning of food processing equipment and surfaces in food contact zones may be stored within or in close proximity to a processing area, provided that access to the chemical storage facility is restricted to only authorized personnel.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.4.5** Personnel who handle hazardous chemicals and toxic substances, including pesticides and cleaning chemicals; i. Shall be fully trained in the purpose of the hazardous chemicals and toxic substances, their storage, handling, and use; ii. Be provided first aid equipment and personnel protective equipment (PPE); and iii. Ensure compliance with the proper identification, storage, usage, disposal, and clean-up requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.4.6** The site shall dispose of empty, obsolete, and unused chemicals, pesticides, toxic substances, and containers in accordance with requirements and ensure that primary containers are: i. Not reused; ii. Segregated and securely stored prior to collection; and iii. Disposed through an approved vendor.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.4.7** In the event of a hazardous spill, the site shall: i. Have spillage clean-up instructions to ensure that the spill is properly contained; and ii. Be equipped with PPE, spillage kits, and cleaning equipment.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.6.5 Loading, Transport, and Unloading Practices

Document #QMS-PRC0035 detailed the requirements for the Receiving of Materials procedure and document #QMS-PRC0037 detailed the requirements of the Shipping procedure. Vehicles used for transporting food within the site and from the site were inspected prior to loading to ensure they were clean, in good repair, suitable for the purpose, and free from odors or other conditions that could impact negatively the product. An Inbound Clean Truck Affidavit was used to document the inspection of incoming transport vehicles, a Drop Trailer Cleaning & Inspection Log was used to document the inspection of the vehicles used to transport product between the manufacturing facilities and the off-site warehouse and an Outbound Clean Truck Affidavit was used to document the inspection of the vehicles used to delivery finished goods to the customer. The Drop Trailer Cleaning & Inspection Log and Outbound Clean Truck Affidavits were reviewed for the 01//12/2022 production date identified in the product trace exercise. All transport vehicles were required to be secured while in transit. Inbound vehicles were secured with a traceable seal, transfer vehicles were locked and outbound LTLs were locked and outbound full load trailer were secured with a company provided traceable seal. The loading practices observed were designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining product and package integrity during loading and transport. The boxed nuts & seeds and nut & seed butter and spreads produced by the company were ambient temperature, shelf stable products that were not required to be stored or transported under refrigerated conditions. The unloading practices observed were designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining product and package integrity. No chilled or frozen materials were received at the manufacturing sites or off-site warehouse.

- 11.6.5.1** The practices applied during loading, transport, and unloading of food shall be documented, implemented, and designed to maintain appropriate storage conditions and product integrity. Foods shall be loaded, transported, and unloaded under conditions suitable to prevent cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.5.2** Vehicles (e.g., trucks/vans/containers) used for transporting food within the site and from the site shall be inspected prior to loading to ensure they are clean, in good repair, suitable for the purpose, and free from odors or other conditions that may impact negatively on the product.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.5.3** Vehicles (e.g., trucks/vans/containers) shall be secured from tampering using seals or other agreed-upon and acceptable devices or systems.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.5.4** Loading and unloading docks shall be designed to protect the product during loading and unloading. Loading practices shall be designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining product and package integrity during loading and transport.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.6.5.5** Refrigerated units shall maintain the product at the required temperature. The unit's temperature settings shall be set, checked, and recorded before loading, and the product temperature shall be recorded at regular intervals during loading, as applicable.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: The boxed nuts & seeds and nut & seed butter and spreads produced by the company were ambient temperature, shelf stable products that were not required to be stored or transported under refrigerated conditions.

- 11.6.5.6** The refrigeration unit shall be operational at all times and checks completed of the unit's operation, the door seals, and the storage temperature at regular intervals during transit.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: The boxed nuts & seeds and nut & seed butter and spreads produced by the company were ambient temperature, shelf stable products that were not required to be stored or transported under refrigerated conditions.

11.6.5.7 On arrival, prior to opening the doors, the food transport vehicle's refrigeration unit's storage temperature settings and operating temperature shall be checked and recorded. Unloading shall be completed efficiently, and product temperatures shall be recorded at the start of unloading and regular intervals during unloading.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: No chilled or frozen materials were received at the manufacturing sites or off-site warehouse.

11.6.5.8 Unloading practices shall be designed to minimize unnecessary exposure of the product to conditions detrimental to maintaining product and package integrity.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.1 High-Risk Processes

The tree nut filling, seed filling, bulk filling, and almond filling rooms in the Main Facility and peanut butter bulk, peanut butter jar, and peanut butter processing rooms in the Peanut Facility were identified as high-risk production areas. Ambient air in high-risk areas was microbiological tested at least annually to confirm that it does not pose a risk to food safety. The test results for the ambient air testing conducted on 03/10/2022 were reviewed. The air samples were evaluated for yeast and mold, all test results were recorded as <20, with the exception of a mold test result for the bulk filling room, which was recorded as 60 cfu/m3. Areas in which high-risk processes were conducted were serviced by personnel dedicated to that function or personnel were required to don a protective outer garment if entering into a raw processing area, additionally personnel in the Peanut facility were required to don protective "booties" over footwear when entering into the low-risk production areas. All personnel were required to wash and sanitize their hands and pass through a dry quat granular "footbath" prior to entering into any high risk area. Product transfer points, with the exception of the seed roaster, were located and designed so they did not compromise the high-risk segregation and minimized the risk of cross-contamination. Major Non Conformance: The design and positioning of the roaster in the seed room was such that the post lethality product was not adequately protected from contamination. The raw seed infeed conveyor and hopper to the roaster were located directly above the outlet and exposed product cooling pans for the roasted product, such that any raw product spilling out of the infeed equipment could potential fall into the roasted seeds. A minor accumulation of raw sesame seed was observed on the cover of the infeed hopper during the audit.

11.7.1.1 The processing of high-risk food shall be conducted under controlled conditions, such that sensitive areas, in which the high-risk food has undergone a "kill" step, a "food safety intervention" or is subject to post-process handling, are protected/segregated from other processes, raw materials, or staff who handle raw materials, to ensure cross-contamination is minimized.

RESPONSE: MAJOR

EVIDENCE: The design and positioning of the roaster in the seed room was such that the post lethality product was not adequately protected from contamination. The raw seed infeed conveyor and hopper to the roaster were located directly above the outlet and exposed product cooling pans for the roasted product, such that any raw product spilling out of the infeed equipment could potential fall into the roasted seeds. A minor accumulation of raw sesame seed was observed on the cover of the infeed hopper during the audit.

ROOT CAUSE: Design of roaster and area did not fully assure raw material could not enter the process or packaging area.

CORRECTIVE ACTION: 1. Design a temporary seal around the hopper to prevent any seeds from falling into finished product carts. 2. Add a visual inspection of the hopper for any spillage on the Seed Room - Pre-Op Inspection Form. 3. Add a daily cleaning task to the Master Sanitation Schedule to inspect/clean the top of the raw hopper. 4. Design an enclosure around raw hopper above the roaster to exclude the possibility of raw seeds from entering the finished product stream and providing complete separation from the finished product packaging area.

VERIFICATION OF CLOSEOUT: Effectiveness of implementation to be verified during the next recertification audit.

COMPLETION DATE: 05/01/2022 **CLOSEOUT DATE:** 05/03/2022

11.7.1.2 Ambient air in high-risk areas shall be tested at least annually to confirm that it does not pose a risk to food safety.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.1.3 Areas in which high-risk processes are conducted shall only be serviced by staff dedicated to that function.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.1.4 Staff engaged in high-risk areas shall change into clean clothing and footwear or temporary protective outerwear when entering high-risk areas. Staff access points shall be located, designed, and equipped to enable staff to change into the distinctive protective clothing and practice a high standard of personal hygiene to prevent product contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.1.5 Product transfer points shall be located and designed, so they do not compromise high-risk segregation and minimize the risk of cross-contamination.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.2 Thawing of Food

No thawing of food was conducted at the manufacturing or off-site warehouse facilities.

11.7.2.1 Thawing of food shall be undertaken in equipment and rooms appropriate for the purpose. Equipment for water thawing shall be continuous flow to ensure the water exchange rate and temperature do not contribute to product deterioration or contamination. Water overflow shall be directed into the floor drainage system and not onto the floor or shall be appropriately plumbed.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

11.7.2.2 Air thawing facilities shall be designed to thaw food under controlled conditions at a rate and temperature that does not contribute to product deterioration or contamination.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

11.7.2.3 Provision is to be made for the containment and regular disposal of used cartons and packaging from thawed product so that there is no risk to the product.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

11.7.3 Control of Foreign Matter Contamination

Document #QMS-PLC0003 detailed the requirements for Foreign Material Control. Document #QMS-PLC0023 detailed the requirements of the Glass, Hard Plastic and Physical Contamination Control Policy. No unauthorized source of glass, porcelain, ceramics, laboratory glassware, or other similar materials were observed in the food processing and handling areas of the facilities. The Glass and Brittle Plastic Monthly Audit Matrix and Glass and Brittle Plastics Audit forms were used as the glass and brittle plastic inventories for each production area and an audit of each area was conducted on a monthly frequency. Glass instrument dial covers on processing equipment and MIG thermometers were not stated or observed to be used. The Glass, Hard Plastic and Physical Contamination Control Policy detailed the procedure to be followed in the event of a glass breakage incident. A Glass Breakage Action Report, document #QMS-FORM0066, was required to be completed in the event of a breakage incident, including glass containers/jars used for the packing of the nut & seed butters. Product contact surfaces, utensils or other equipment were not permitted or observed to be constructed with wood. Wooden pallets used in food processing and handling areas were dedicated for that purpose, clean, and maintained in good order. No loose metal objects on equipment, equipment covers, and overhead structures were observed during the audit. Document #QMS-PLC0063 detailed the requirements of the Tool/Utensil/Knife Control policy. Snap-off style blade utility knives were not permitted or observed to be used in the manufacturing or storage areas. The planned and preventative maintenance program was used to ensure gaskets, rubber impellers, and other equipment made of materials that could wear or deteriorate over time were inspected on a regular frequency.

11.7.3.1 The responsibility and methods used to prevent foreign matter contamination of the product shall be documented, implemented, and communicated to all staff. Inspections shall be performed (refer to 2.5.4.3) to ensure plant and equipment remain in good condition and equipment has not become detached or deteriorated and is free from potential contaminants.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.3.2 Containers, equipment, and other utensils made of glass, porcelain, ceramics, laboratory glassware, or other similar materials shall not be permitted in food processing /contact zones (except where the product is contained in packaging made from these materials, or measurement instruments with glass dial covers are used, or MIG thermometers are required under regulation). Where glass objects or similar material are required in food handling/contact zones, they shall be listed in a glass inventory, including details of their location and condition.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.3.3 Regular inspections of food handling/contact zones shall be conducted (refer to 2.5.4.3) to ensure they are free of glass or other like material and to establish changes to the condition of the objects listed in the glass inventory.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.7.3.4 Glass instrument dial covers on processing equipment and MIG thermometers shall be inspected at the start of each shift to confirm they have not been damaged.

RESPONSE: NOT APPLICABLE

EVIDENCE: Glass instrument dial covers on processing equipment and MIG thermometers were not stated or observed to be used.

11.7.3.5	In circumstances where glass or similar material breakage occurs, the affected area shall be isolated, cleaned, thoroughly inspected (including cleaning equipment and footwear), and cleared by a suitably responsible person prior to the start of operations. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.3.6	Wooden pallets and other wooden utensils used in food processing and handling areas shall be dedicated for that purpose, clean, and maintained in good order. Their condition shall be subject to regular inspection. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.3.7	Loose metal objects on equipment, equipment covers, and overhead structures shall be removed or tightly fixed so as not to present a hazard. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.3.8	Knives and cutting instruments used in processing and packaging operations shall be controlled, kept clean, and well maintained. Snap-off blades shall not be used in manufacturing or storage areas. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.3.9	Gaskets, rubber impellers, and other equipment made of materials that can wear or deteriorate over time shall be inspected on a regular frequency (refer to 2.5.4.3). RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.4	Detection of Foreign Objects Destoners, gravity separator, air aspirators, magnets, inline screens/strainers, and metal detection systems were used to remove or detect foreign matter. Destoning and gravity separation was used for the raw peanuts, air aspiration was used for the cashews and to remove the peanut skins after blanching, and magnets and inline screens/strainer were used for all processes. Metal detection was identified as a PPC/CCP in each of the food safety plans, as detailed in the response to 2.4.3. All finished product was required to be passed through a metal detection system. Pipeline metal detector were used for the butters and spreads and inline conveyor metal detection was used for the boxed seed and nut products. The pipeline metal detectors were equipped with a pneumatically operated reject valve and the inline metal detection systems were equipped with pneumatically operated push arms that removed the suspect product from the process flow. The metal detection records were reviewed, as detailed in the response to 2.4.3.16. The non conforming product hold procedure, as detailed in the response to 2.4.6, was used for all cases of suspected foreign matter contamination.
11.7.4.1	The responsibility, methods, and frequency for monitoring, maintaining, calibrating, and using screens, sieves, filters, or other technologies to remove or detect foreign matter shall be documented and implemented. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.4.2	Where detection and/or removal systems are used, the site shall establish limits for detection, based on a risk assessment of the product and its packaging, and identify the location(s) of the detector(s) in the process. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.4.3	Metal detectors or other physical contaminant detection technologies shall be routinely monitored, validated, and verified for operational effectiveness. The equipment shall be designed to isolate defective product and indicate when it is rejected. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.4.4	Records shall be maintained of the inspection of foreign object detection devices, of any products rejected or removed by them, and of corrective and preventative actions resulting from the inspections. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT
11.7.4.5	In all cases of foreign matter contamination, the affected batch or item shall be isolated, inspected, reworked, or disposed of. Records shall be maintained of the disposition. RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

11.8.1 Waste Disposal

Document #QMS-PLC0036 detailed the requirements of the Waste Management and Control Policy. Waste was removed at sufficient intervals to prevent excessive accumulations in the food processing and handling areas of the facility. Waste disposal equipment, collection bins, and storage areas were maintained in a serviceable condition, cleaned, and sanitized regularly to prevent the attraction of pests and other vermin. Solid processing waste was collected and stored in externally located, lidded dumpsters prior to being removed from the site for disposal. Inedible waste, including butters contained in lined box and peanut skins collected in bulk supersacs that was intended for use as a source of animal feed was stored and handled so that it did not cause a risk to the animal or further processing. Document #QMS-PRC0052 detailed the requirements of the Product Destruction/Disposal Procedure. The Product Disposal- Destruction Release Form was reviewed for the controlled disposal conducted on 08/17/2021. Waste water was collected via the floor drainage system and discharged directly to the municipal sewerage system. The manufacturing facilities were primarily dry processing area; water was only introduced to the areas during wet cleaning activities. Line audits, GMP audits, and pre-operational inspections were utilized to review the effectiveness of waste management program

- 11.8.1.1** The responsibility and methods used to collect and handle dry, wet, and liquid waste and how to store it prior to removal from the premises shall be documented and implemented.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.2** Waste shall be removed on a regular basis and not allowed to build up in food handling or processing areas. Designated waste accumulation areas shall be maintained in a clean and tidy condition until external waste collection is undertaken.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.3** Waste and overflow water from tubs, tanks, and other equipment shall be discharged directly to the floor drainage system or by an alternative method that meets local regulatory requirements.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.4** Trolleys, vehicle waste disposal equipment, collection bins, and storage areas shall be maintained in a serviceable condition, cleaned, and sanitized regularly to prevent the attraction of pests and other vermin.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.5** Adequate provision shall be made for the disposal of all solid processing waste, including trimmings, inedible material, and used packaging.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.6** Where applicable, a documented procedure shall be in place for the controlled disposal of trademarked materials waste considered high-risk for handling or other reasons. Where a contracted disposal service is used, the disposal process shall be reviewed regularly to confirm compliance.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.7** Inedible waste designated for animal feed shall be stored and handled so that it will not cause a risk to the animal or further processing. If denaturant is used to identify inedible waste, it shall be demonstrated that it does not pose a risk to animal health.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.8** Waste held on-site prior to disposal shall be stored in a separate storage facility that is suitably insect proofed and located where it does not present any hazards.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.9** Adequate provision shall be made for the disposal of all liquid waste from processing and food handling areas. Liquid waste shall either be removed from the processing environment continuously or held in a designated storage area in lidded containers prior to disposal where it does not present any hazards.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

- 11.8.1.10** Reviews of the effectiveness of waste management shall form part of regular site inspections (refer to 2.5.4.3), and the results of these inspections shall be included in the relevant inspection reports.

RESPONSE: COMPLIANT

EVIDENCE: .

